Atlas of the Heart

Mapping Meaningful Connection and the Language of Human Experience

Brené Brown

Chapter-by-chapter notes ● first-reading companion ● personal study

How to read these notes

Blue box: “Place in the argument”: why the chapter is here and why it carries its title, drawn from Brown’s own statements.

Gold box: “How this chapter builds the author’s case”: links to earlier and later chapters.

Headings: Chapter titles and sub-headings are the book’s exact words, in the book’s order.

Quotation marks: Exact words from the book. Everything else is close paraphrase that keeps her terms and steps of reasoning.

Bold: Terms Brown defines or names.

Length: Notes for each chapter are capped at one-third of that chapter’s source characters (ratio 1:3); shorter is better.

Structure: The book has no Parts, so there are no Part overviews. Page numbers sit on the outer edge; gutter is mirrored.

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The Architecture of the Book at a Glance

The book has no Parts. Brown says it explores "eighty-seven emotions and experiences that have been organized into groups," one group per chapter.

Unit	Title in the book	Terms listed under the title
Intro	Introduction	How It Started; How It's Going; Making Meaning; You Are Here
1	Places We Go When Things Are Uncertain or Too Much	Stress, Overwhelm, Anxiety, Worry, Avoidance, Excitement, Dread, Fear, Vulnerability
2	Places We Go When We Compare	Comparison, Admiration, Reverence, Envy, Jealousy, Resentment, Schadenfreude, Freudenfreude
3	Places We Go When Things Don't Go as Planned	Boredom, Disappointment, Expectations, Regret, Discouragement, Resignation, Frustration
4	Places We Go When It's Beyond Us	Awe, Wonder, Confusion, Curiosity, Interest, Surprise
5	Places We Go When Things Aren't What They Seem	Amusement, Bittersweetness, Nostalgia, Cognitive Dissonance, Paradox, Irony, Sarcasm
6	Places We Go When We're Hurting	Anguish, Hopelessness, Despair, Sadness, Grief
7	Places We Go with Others	Compassion, Pity, Empathy, Sympathy, Boundaries, Comparative Suffering
8	Places We Go When We Fall Short	Shame, Self-Compassion, Perfectionism, Guilt, Humiliation, Embarrassment
9	Places We Go When We Search for Connection	Belonging, Fitting In, Connection, Disconnection, Insecurity, Invisibility, Loneliness
10	Places We Go When the Heart Is Open	Love, Lovelessness, Heartbreak, Trust, Self-Trust, Betrayal, Defensiveness, Flooding, Hurt
11	Places We Go When Life Is Good	Joy, Happiness, Calm, Contentment, Gratitude, Foreboding Joy, Relief, Tranquility
12	Places We Go When We Feel Wronged	Anger, Contempt, Disgust, Dehumanization, Hate, Self-Righteousness
13	Places We Go to Self-Assess	Pride, Hubris, Humility
Close	Cultivating Meaningful Connection	Theory; Near Enemies; A Grounded Theory on Cultivating Meaningful Connection; Language and Meaningful Connection; Atlas of the Heart

The book's purpose, in the author's words

"I want this book to be an atlas for all of us, because I believe that with an adventurous heart and the right maps, we can travel anywhere and never fear losing ourselves."

"To form meaningful connections with others, we must first connect with ourselves, but to do either, we must first establish a common understanding of the language of emotion and human experience."

Introduction

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
The Introduction opens on a Rumi epigraph: the heart is a sea, language the shore. Its four sections run from Brown's own story (How It Started), to the evidence that language shapes emotion (How It's Going), to how the book's emotions were chosen and grouped (Making Meaning), to the map metaphor that organises what follows (You Are Here). Her aim: "I want this book to be an atlas for all of us."

How It Started

- She is "not a sentimental keeper of things"; packing up relatives' houses is "an emotional minefield." An old college paper and a box of memorabilia sent her back to her 1987 self and raised the question "Why have I been thinking about emotions for so long?"
- Her family: "a very tough, suck-it-up-get-it-done-and-don't-talk-about-feelings family." Her parents had "a hard upbringing with a lot of trauma." At home "There was intense love and there was intense rage." As the oldest of four she was "the protector," and by middle school she had diagnosed herself as "crazy."
- Why she assumed it was her: "nothing, I mean nothing, was discussed or normalized in my family." "For children, it's easy for everything to become a source of shame when nothing is normalized. You assume that if no one is talking about it, it must be just you." Her parents "were and are good people who did the very best they could with the tools they had," but "predictably good outside the house, and wildly unpredictable inside, I assumed it was us."
- Her "magic powers": "I could tell you with stunning accuracy what was going to happen in twenty minutes." She knew "which snarky comment would produce a laugh and which one would set off a fight," and "everyone's shame triggers and the unwanted identities that elicited their shame."
- Examples: the swim coach who "liked effort more than natural talent" and loved backstroke, so she picked the lane of those "dying by the time they reached the wall." The piano teacher: she stood up and said "Me" to protect a friend, and told the principal's assistant she would not talk until her parents came. Her dad was proud, but "it wasn't a warm and fuzzy moment for me. The irony was too obvious."
- Her conclusion: "Maybe I couldn't actually predict the future, but I did have top-level observation powers." She understood "that people would do almost anything to not feel pain, including causing pain and abusing power," and that few can be held accountable "without rationalizing, blaming, or shutting down." Others seemed "disembodied from their own inner world and disconnected from other people. Too many lonely and secret lives."
- In her late teens and twenties "my power of observation was dulled by a thick layer of beer, cigarettes, dance halls." "Being able to see what's coming doesn't make it any less painful when it arrives." "The eggshells weren't on the ground; they were duct-taped to the soles of my shoes."
- "We see the pain caused by the misuse of power, so we numb our pain and lose track of our own power." "If understanding power and the connections between the way we feel, think, and act was my superpower, numbing was my kryptonite." Inspired by her mom, "I got sober and started doing my own work." It meant "years of terrifying change, hard goodbyes, and boundaries."
- The edges: "taking the edge off is not rewarding, but putting the edge back on is one of the most worthwhile things we can do." Sharp edges "feel vulnerable, but they are also the markers that let us know where we end and others begin." "Trying to outrun and outsmart vulnerability and pain is choosing a life defined by suffering and exhaustion."
- Power: "the abuse of power or using power over others is the opposite of courage; it's a desperate attempt to maintain a very fragile ego." "When people are hateful or cruel or just being assholes, they're showing us exactly what they're afraid of."

- “Sometimes, even when the pain takes your breath away, you have to let the people you love experience the consequences of their own behavior. That one really hurts.”
- Accountability: “when you hold someone accountable for hurtful behaviors and they feel shame, that’s not the same as shaming someone. I am responsible for holding you accountable in a respectful and productive way. I’m not responsible for your emotional reaction to that accountability.”
- “I will never have to stop learning these things.” Her belief: “the center will hold if, and only if, we can feel the edges.”

How It’s Going

- After over twenty years studying “how we think, feel, and act,” the biggest barriers are the same as in childhood: “People will do almost anything to not feel pain”; “Very few people can handle being held accountable without rationalizing, blaming, or shutting down”; and “Without understanding how our feelings, thoughts, and behaviors work together, it’s almost impossible to find our way back to ourselves and each other.”
- The data: fifteen years ago, with her shame resilience curriculum, surveys of “more than seven thousand people” asked them to list the emotions they could name as they experienced them. “The average number of emotions named across the surveys was three. The emotions were happy, sad, and angry.”
- Wittgenstein: “The limits of my language mean the limits of my world.” Her image: a doctor’s visit with “tape over your mouth and your hands are tied behind your back.” Unable to articulate emotion, “We feel hopeless or we feel a destructive level of anger.”
- “Language is our portal to meaning-making, connection, healing, learning, and self-awareness.” “Naming an experience doesn’t give the experience more power, it gives us the power of understanding and meaning.” Language “can actually shape what we’re feeling.”
- When access to emotional language is blocked, “our ability to interpret incoming emotional information is significantly diminished”; the correct words make us better at identifying emotions “in others, as well as” in ourselves.
- “Language speeds and strengthens connections in the brain when we are processing sensory information.” Labeling emotional experience “is related to greater emotion regulation and psychosocial well-being.”
- **Emotional granularity** is “Our ability to accurately recognize and label emotions.” Susan David: “Learning to label emotions with a more nuanced vocabulary can be absolutely transformative.” Those who distinguish many emotions “do much, much better at managing the ups and downs of ordinary existence than those who see everything in black and white.” Emotions “can be beacons, not barriers.”

Making Meaning

- Eduardo Bericat: “As human beings we can only experience life emotionally.” Her hope: to “open up that language portal” to “a universe of new choices and second chances.” Her own family, parents included, “now has the language and skill to align the love we feel with the way we actually show up with each other.”
- The book explores “eighty-seven emotions and experiences” organized into groups, “because some of these are not emotions—they’re thoughts that lead to emotion.” LeDoux: “there are as many theories of emotions as there are emotion theorists.”
- Fridlund: “no one agrees on how to define emotion.” Still, 80 percent of experts now agree on universal voice and facial expression signals. Ekman sees seven universal emotion “families”; Cowen and Keltner say “at least twenty-seven or twenty-eight.” Brown takes “a broader approach”: “These nuances matter.”

- Experts define emotion variously, for example “Your mind’s reaction to experience” and “The description of intangible human feelings.” Fields studying it include “philosophy, sociology, psychology, neuroscience, medicine, and mental health.”
- Method: an online course, 2013 to 2014, with “66,625 participants” and “more than 550,000 comments,” analyzed with two questions: which emotions emerge most often, and which people “struggle to name or label.” This yielded “approximately 150.” Therapists tagged each red, yellow, or green; “all green stickers were automatically included.”
- With Dr. Ronda Dearing she reviewed “close to fifteen hundred academic publications” over three years, adding words “for comparative reasons” (jealousy and envy). In 2020 summer interns (Ellen and Prerna) said grouping terms “that highlighted the subtle and not-so-subtle differences” teaches better than alphabetical order.
- Her commitment: “work that is empirically based and accessible and that resonates with our lived experiences and lived language.” “I’m a social worker before I’m anything else, and ‘meeting people where they are’ is an ethical mandate.”
- Her audience: research participants, practitioners and educators. “If the research participants, practitioners, and educators don’t get what I’m saying, or find it irrelevant because of how it’s presented, I’ve failed.”
- “I want this book to be an atlas for all of us, because I believe that with an adventurous heart and the right maps, we can travel anywhere and never fear losing ourselves.”

You Are Here

- “I am a mapmaker and a traveler.” “I don’t have the answers. I have data.” There are places she cannot map: “For this work, we are all the mapmakers and the travelers.”
- Cartographer Kirk Goldsberry: “maps are about layers,” and all maps “provide readers with orientation.” “The interaction between the layers is the story of the map.” “Maps are the most important documents in human history.” “We are meaning makers, and a sense of place is central to meaning-making.”
- Goldsberry: “50 to 60 percent of the challenge of mapmaking is labeling the map in a way that appropriately prioritizes the right information.” Whether looking at a map of Texas or at a tough conversation, “we need landmarks to orient us, and we need language to label what we’re experiencing.”
- The orienting questions: “Where am I?” “How did I get here from there?” “How do I get there from here?”
- Emotion’s layers are “biology, biography, behavior, and backstory”: how emotions “show up in our bodies and why”; how “our families and communities shape our beliefs”; “our go-to” behaviors; and “the context.” “These are the questions that help us make meaning of our lives.”
- The ending: “that shore, that solid ground, is within us. The anchor we are searching for is connection, and it is internal.” “To form meaningful connections with others, we must first connect with ourselves, but to do either, we must first establish a common understanding of the language of emotion and human experience.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case

The Introduction supplies the premise (language makes emotion usable), the evidence (most people name only happy, sad and angry), the method (87 grouped terms) and the metaphor (biology, biography, behavior, backstory). The next chapters “explore eighty-seven emotions and experiences that have been organized into groups.”

CHAPTER 1

Places We Go When Things Are Uncertain or Too Much

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title

Chapter 1 opens the atlas with the places we go when we feel unsafe or overloaded. The book lists its terms under the title: stress, overwhelm, anxiety, worry, avoidance, excitement, dread, fear, vulnerability. The order moves from overload, to anxiety and fear about what may come, to vulnerability, which Brown defines as the emotion of "uncertainty, risk, and emotional exposure."

Stressed and Overwhelmed

- A recurring bad dream: a packed restaurant, angry tables, and "only one waiter showed up for the shift. And it's me." After "six years of waiting tables and bartending," "the pressure left a mark." "The language and habits of that job were survival, and they stuck."
- "In the weeds" brings the response "What do you need?" and "happened to everyone on almost every shift." "Blown" is "completely different. The kitchen gets really quiet": the manager reassigns your tables and you get ten minutes. "Stressed is being in the weeds. Overwhelmed is being blown."

Stressed

- "We feel stressed when we evaluate environmental demand as beyond our ability to cope successfully. This includes elements of unpredictability, uncontrollability, and feeling overloaded."
- "Our emotional reaction is more tied to our cognitive assessment of whether we can cope with the situation than to how our body is reacting."
- "Chronic exposure to stressors can be detrimental to health": "decreased immune function, greater inflammatory processes, less sleep."

Overwhelmed

- "Overwhelmed means an extreme level of stress, an emotional and/or cognitive intensity to the point of feeling unable to function." Merriam-Webster: "completely overcome or overpowered by thought or feeling."
- Jon Kabat-Zinn: the feeling "that our lives are somehow unfolding faster than the human nervous system and psyche are able to manage well." His cure is "no-agenda, non-doing time," which is why blown waiters were simply asked to do nothing.
- When overwhelmed "we don't process other emotional information accurately." Carol Gohm: emotions intense, focus moderate, clarity low. Brown's scale: feeling emotions "at about 10," paying attention "at about 5," understanding "at about 2." This is "not a setup for successful decision making."
- Both are "about our narrative of emotional and mental depletion—there's just too much going on to manage effectively."

Anxiety

- Anxiety is the "Willy Wonka shit tunnel": a sweet boat ride turning into "an escalating scene of fear and loss of control," while Wonka recites a poem at a "frenetic rate."
- "Escalating loss of control, worst-case-scenario thinking and imagery, and total uncertainty."

Let. Me. Off. The. Boat.

- The research on language "felt like a life jacket."
- A **trait** is "part of an individual's personality and therefore a long-term characteristic"; a **state** is "a temporary condition." Telling them apart "can often be difficult." **Generalized anxiety disorder** is "different from both": "excessive worry about everyday issues and situations," lasting longer than six months.
- "Approximately one-third of U.S. adults" will be affected, yet "fewer than half" seek treatment; "It's very difficult to work through an anxiety disorder without professional help."

- “An intolerance for uncertainty is an important contributing factor to all types of anxiety.” It leads to “worry or avoidance,” and “neither of these coping strategies is very effective.”
- **Worry** “is not an emotion; it’s the thinking part of anxiety,” “a chain of negative thoughts about bad things that might happen in the future.” Worriers believe it helps (it does not), believe it is uncontrollable, and suppress it, “which actually strengthens and reinforces worry.” Instead “dig into and address the emotion driving the thinking.”
- **Avoidance** “isn’t benign.” Harriet Lerner: “It is not fear that stops you from doing the brave and true thing… the problem is avoidance.” It “will make you feel less vulnerable in the short run, but it will never make you less afraid.”
- “The entire premise of this book is that language has the power to define our experiences.” Anxiety and excitement “feel the same, but how we interpret and label them can determine how we experience them.” “The labels are important because they help us know what to do next.”
- **Dread** “occurs frequently in response to high-probability negative events; its magnitude increases as the dreaded event draws nearer.” We often prefer to get unpleasant things over with, even if sooner is more unpleasant.
- “For anxiety and dread, the threat is in the future. For fear, the threat is now—in the present.” **Fear** is “a negative, short-lasting, high-alert emotion in response to a perceived threat.” Responses: “fight, flight, or freeze.” One item is on every list of fears: “the fear of social rejection,” since “social pain and physical pain” share a brain region.
- Lerner: “anxiety and fear have helped every species to be wary and to survive.” Both “need to be understood and respected, perhaps even befriended.”

Vulnerability

- “Vulnerability is the emotion that we experience during times of uncertainty, risk, and emotional exposure.” It “first emerged in my dissertation research, and it has been validated by every study I’ve done since.”
- Examples from “tens of thousands of people”: “The first date after my divorce,” “Starting my own business,” “Waiting for the doctor to call back.”
- “There is no evidence that they are indicators of weakness.” Across cultures we were raised to believe vulnerable means weak, and also to be brave. “There is no courage without vulnerability. Courage requires the willingness to lean into uncertainty, risk, and emotional exposure.”
- Embracing it “emerged as the prerequisite for all of the daring leadership behaviors.”
- Against “perfectionism, pleasing, and proving” as armor: “Vulnerability is not oversharing, it’s sharing with people who have earned the right to hear our stories and our experiences.”
- “Vulnerability is not weakness; it’s our greatest measure of courage.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case

The chapter builds from being swamped (stress, overwhelm), through the future-facing threat (anxiety, worry, avoidance, dread) and present threat (fear), to vulnerability, the exposure that courage requires. It gives the book’s first proof of its premise: one body sensation named anxiety or excitement changes what we do next.

CHAPTER 2

Places We Go When We Compare

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title

Chapter 2 gathers the experiences "connected to comparison." Brown's stated goal is to "raise our awareness about how and why they happen so we can name them, think about them, and make choices that reflect our values and our heart." It begins with comparison itself, moves through admiration, reverence, envy, jealousy and resentment, and ends on schadenfreude and its opposite, freudenfreude.

Comparison

- Lap swimming is "exercise, meditation, and alone time," ruined only when she shifts attention "to what's happening in the lanes next to me." She catches herself "racing the person next to me," and "once hurt my shoulder trying to race a twentysomething triathlete." A picture in her study reminds her "to stop checking the lanes next to me," which applies to "how I parent, my work, my relationships."
- "Like it or not, I'm probably going to check the lanes next to me. But what I do next is up to me."
- "Comparison is actually not an emotion, but it drives all sorts of big feelings that can affect our relationships and our self-worth." Social comparison "falls outside of our awareness," which "can lead to us showing up in ways that are hurtful to ourselves and others."
- Suls, Martin and Wheeler: comparing the self with others "is a pervasive social phenomenon," used to evaluate outcomes and "to predict future prospects." Guidepost #6 of wholehearted living is "cultivating creativity and letting go of comparison": "Comparison is a creativity killer, among other things."
- Her definition: "Comparison is the crush of conformity from one side and competition from the other—it's trying to simultaneously fit in and stand out." Comparison says, "Be like everyone else, but better."
- Conforming and competing are not mutually exclusive: we rank around "alike things." "We don't compare our house to the mansions across town; we compare our yard to the yards on our block." The mandate is a "crushing paradox": "It's not be yourself and respect others for being authentic, it's 'Fit in, but win.'"
- Upward comparison is to someone "better than we are," downward to someone "worse"; "The direction of the comparison doesn't guarantee the direction of the outcome" (Nortje). Frank Fujita: "frequent social comparisons are not associated with life satisfaction or the positive emotions of love and joy but are associated with the negative emotions of fear, anger, shame, and sadness."
- Many social psychologists see comparison as something that "happens to us." But "we can choose whether or not to let that comparison affect our mood or self-perceptions."
- Scott Sonenshein (Stretch): "the grass is always greener." Because of how grass grows, when we peer over the fence it "actually does look greener, even if it is truly the same lushness." "It's all perspective."
- "Our hardwiring makes us default to comparison." Her strategy: look at the swimmer in the next lane and think, "Have a great swim." That way "I acknowledge the inevitable and make a conscious decision to wish them well." "The more we know, the more we can choose connection over comparison."

Admiration and Reverence

- **Admiration**: we feel it "when someone's abilities, accomplishments, or character inspires us." It leads to "wanting to improve ourselves," not to be the person: "we just want to be better versions of ourselves." Example: female athletes ("But the senior tour").

- **Reverence** (adoration, worship, veneration) "is a deeper form of admiration or respect and is often combined with a sense of meaningful connection with something greater than ourselves": "deep respect, love, and humility for something sacred or transcendent."
- "Admiration fosters self-betterment, reverence seems to foster a desire for connection": "we want to move closer."
- Bonus word, irreverent (the Netflix tag): "not showing the expected respect for official, important, or holy things." Her experience of "unchecked authority" makes her wary of reverence; her upbringing makes her uncomfortable with irreverence: "I sometimes laugh at irreverent humor. Then I feel bad."

Envy and Jealousy

- "I've been using these words all wrong." We say "I'm so jealous" when we are envious, because we don't like to say we're envious.
- "Envy occurs when we want something that another person has." "Jealousy is when we fear losing a relationship or a valued part of a relationship that we already have." Smith and Kim: envy "typically involves two people"; jealousy "typically involves three people."

Envy

- A 2015 study: "90 percent of recalled episodes of envy" fall into attraction, competence or wealth.
- Some envy "comes with hostility" ("I want that, and I don't want you to have it"); some doesn't ("I want that, but you can have it too"). Hostility "makes it tough to own that emotion": "I'm envious, but not the bad kind. Swear."

Jealousy

- It is "a cognitive evaluation in response to feeling anger, sadness, and/or fear": "we think jealousy in response to how we feel." Chung and Harris: a triad of two people and a rival, with threats to "a loved one's attention, affection, or resources."
- It appears in parent/child, sibling, friend and coworker relationships, even when a partner "spends a lot of time alone, doing something that doesn't involve us."
- More socially acceptable than envy, it "can often lead to more dire consequences": high jealousy "directly related to problem drinking and to interpersonal violence."
- Small doses are normal. Maya Angelou: "Jealousy in romance is like salt in food. A little can enhance the savor, but too much can spoil the pleasure."
- Why avoid "envious"? It is one of the "seven deadly sins," and "jealous" can sound "almost complimentary" ("I'm so jelly").
- The tools now let us ask: "Am I fearful of losing something I value to another person, or do I want something someone else has?" If the latter, "do I want to see them lose it, or is it not about that?"

Resentment

- A "lifelong struggle." Unwanted identity "is the most powerful elicitor of shame"; "Resentful" and "bitter" are on her list.
- She assumed it was anger tied to perfectionism, directed at people not "working or sacrificing or grinding or perfecting." Then on the podcast she asked Marc Brackett, "Is resentment part of the anger family?" He replied, "No. Resentment is part of envy."
- The reframe: "I'm not mad because you're resting. I'm mad because I'm so bone tired and I want to rest." "Your lack of work is not making me resentful, my lack of rest is making me resentful."
- Home for the Holidays (1995): the perfectionist sister, "bitter and resentful and exhausted," on her StairMaster: "This is the only thing I do all day that I like." "Painfully relatable."
- Now she asks, "What do I need but am afraid to ask for?" She recognizes it by the thought "What mean and critical thing am I rehearsing saying to this person?"
- Definition: "Resentment is the feeling of frustration, judgment, anger, 'better than,' and/or hidden envy related to perceived unfairness or injustice. It's an emotion that we often experience when we

fail to set boundaries or ask for what we need, or when expectations let us down because they were based on things we can't control."

Schadenfreude

- German schaden (harm) and freude (joy): "pleasure or joy derived from someone else's suffering or misfortune." (A reader proposed "epicaricacy.")
- "There's a cruelty and insecurity about it." It can "violate our values and lead to feelings of guilt and shame," yet "it's seductive, especially when we're sucked into groupthink."
- "Counterfeit connection": "nothing that celebrates the humiliation or pain of another person builds lasting connection."
- It involves **counter-empathy**: "decreased activity in the area of the brain that processes empathy and increased activity in the reward centers."
- Relief when someone is held accountable "not schadenfreude"; it can come from "empathy for the aggrieved." Holding someone accountable and their feeling shame "does not mean we've shamed them."
- It has "trait-like properties," correlated positively with "envy, aggression, narcissism, and anger" and negatively with "empathy and conscientiousness."
- During the pandemic she asked herself, "Is this who I want to be?" "In the end, I couldn't make it work with my values."
- Smith and van Dijk: "an emotion typically born out of inferiority rather than superiority." She adds "fear, powerlessness, and/or a sense of deservedness."

Freudenfreude

- "The opposite of schadenfreude—it's the enjoyment of another's success. It's also a subset of empathy."
- Chambliss: "Ongoing lack of Freudenfreude eventually can pose a fatal challenge to a relationship."
- Her family teaching: "good friends aren't afraid of your light. They never blow out your flame." Hands cupped around a flame: "No flame blower-outers" meant "more freudenfreude, less schadenfreude."
- **Shoy**: "intentionally sharing the joy of someone relating a success story by showing interest and asking follow-up questions." **Bragitude**: "intentionally tying words of gratitude toward the listener following discussion of personal successes."
- Abby Wambach's "Point and Run": "You will not always be the goal scorer. When you are not, you better be rushing toward her."

How this chapter builds the author's case
The chapter moves from the automatic act of comparing to its outcomes: wanting what others have (envy), fearing loss (jealousy), unmet needs (resentment), and pleasure in harm (schadenfreude). It closes with freudenfreude, the chosen alternative, giving Brown's answer to comparison: "choose connection over comparison."

CHAPTER 3

Places We Go When Things Don't Go as Planned

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
Chapter 3 groups experiences that follow an outcome we did not plan for: boredom, disappointment, expectations, regret, discouragement, resignation and frustration. Boredom comes first, then disappointment and regret, then a short comparison.

Boredom

- **Boredom** "is the uncomfortable state of wanting to engage in satisfying activity, but being unable to do it." When bored "we experience a lack of stimulation, time seems to pass very slowly, and if we're working on tasks, they seem to lack challenge and meaning."
- What is unique is that it "can wind us up and leave us feeling irritable, frustrated, or restless, or, rather than getting us worked up, it can leave us feeling lethargic." With "more control and autonomy over the boring tasks," lethargy is likelier; with "little autonomy and control," frustration.
- Not all boredom is bad: "simple, boring tasks or mundane activities can allow our minds to wander, daydream, and create. The lack of stimulation that defines 'being bored' gives our imagination room to play and grow."
- Her book-writing routine is watching "super predictable, formulaic mysteries": they lull "the easily distracted part of my brain into a rhythmic stupor, setting free the deeper, meaning-making part of my brain." She sits with a notepad "because the more bored I get, the more ideas bubble to the surface."
- Sherry Turkle: "Boredom is your imagination calling to you."

Disappointment and Regret

- They range "from mild discomfort to deep hurt," and "we underestimate both in terms of the disconnection and pain they can cause within us and in our relationships." There are "tools and practices" to set ourselves up for less hurt.

Disappointment

- The definition "emerged from our data": "Disappointment is unmet expectations. The more significant the expectations, the more significant the disappointment."
- "With disappointment, it always starts with expectations," in two categories: unexamined and unexpressed (**stealth expectations**), and examined and expressed.

Unexamined and Unexpressed Expectations (aka Stealth Expectations)

- We set expectations "of ourselves and the people in our lives" every day. The unconscious ones "are the most dangerous and often turn into disappointment"; disappointment "is one of the most frequently experienced emotions, and it tends to be experienced at a high level of intensity."
- We "paint a picture in our head," including what others do in it, so expectations are "set on outcomes totally beyond our control, like what other people think, what they feel, or how they're going to react. The movie in our mind is wonderful, but no one else knows their parts, their lines, or what it means to us."
- When the picture fails to play out, it "requires considerable emotional bandwidth." Eliane Sommerfeld: we feel bad about ourselves and the other person, tinged with "astonishment and surprise." "It's exhausting."
- Her story with Steve: after hectic weekends, "one of us would feel disappointment, resentment, and anger." She told him, "Something about the story we're telling ourselves is not true."
- Steve finally said: "When it's just me with the kids, I have no expectations for getting my own stuff done. I give up my to-do list so I can actually enjoy the craziness." "This fight was all about stealth expectations." Together they set wild expectations, never "reality-check[ed]" or made them explicit, and "tended to blame each other."

- Now they ask, “What do you want this weekend to look like?” Stealth expectations still trip them, but “we help each other,” asking “What’s this about? What are you not saying?” These are “vulnerable conversations, but worth the discomfort.”
- At work, “painting done” means “fully walking through my expectations of what the completed task will look like.” It is “one of the most powerful tools we have.”
- Examples: the holiday planned “to the minute”; the gift (“You have no control over her response. None.”); the team “blown away.” “It’s dangerous to put your self-worth in other people’s hands.” “These are recipes for disappointment and hurt.”
- Her birthday with nothing in the house (“If I have to ask, it’s not worth it”); the therapist: “If you’re not asking for what’s important to you, maybe it’s because you don’t think you are worth it.” Her reply: “You’re fired.”
- “Communicating our expectations is brave and vulnerable.” At Disney, three packed mystery books met “five kids for seven days” once Steve said, “Tell me about those.”

Examined and Expressed Expectations

- Even when expectations are “realistic, clearly communicated, and self-aware,” disappointment “still hurts. Potentially, a lot,” partly “because we were vulnerable and asked for what we needed.”
- Elizabeth, a “shoo-in” for a promotion who did not get it: “Instead of just feeling sad and disappointed, I felt sad, disappointed, and ashamed.” Disappointment is “an incredible opportunity for meaningful connection.” We should “circle back, and talk about our feelings and move to accountability.”
- Lowering expectations minimizes disappointment, but there is “a middle path”: “Examine and express our expectations.” “There are too many people in the world today who decide to live disappointed rather than risk feeling disappointment”.
- The man in his sixties whose wife was killed: “expecting the worst didn’t prepare me at all.” He still grieves “all of those wonderful moments we shared and that I didn’t fully enjoy.”
- Disappointment may be a paper cut, but, as with Haku and the origami birds in Spirited Away, “if those cuts are deep enough or if we accumulate them over a lifetime, they can leave us seriously wounded.”

Regret

- Both arise when an outcome was not what we “wanted, counted on, or thought would happen.” With disappointment we often believe the outcome “was out of our control”; with regret, “caused by our decisions or actions.”
- In the short term we regret bad outcomes where we acted; over the long term, “the actions we didn’t take.”
- Saunders: “What I regret most in my life are failures of kindness.” Many participants echo Saunders.
- “In our research, regret emerged as a function of empathy. And, when used constructively, it’s a call to courage and a path toward wisdom.”
- “The idea of ‘no regrets’ doesn’t mean living with courage, it means living without reflection. To live without regret is to believe we have nothing to learn, no amends to make, and no opportunity to be braver with our lives.”
- “What we regret most are our failures of courage.” Regrets about not taking chances “have made me braver”; about shaming or blaming “have made me more thoughtful.” “Sometimes the most uncomfortable learning is the most powerful.”

Discouraged, Resigned, and Frustrated

- **Disappointed:** “I believe the outcome was outside of my control.” **Regretful:** “the outcome was caused by my decisions, actions, or failure to act.” **Discouraged:** “I’m losing my confidence and enthusiasm about any future effort.” **Resigned:** “I’ve lost my confidence and enthusiasm about any

future effort." **Frustrated:** "Something that feels out of my control is preventing me from achieving my desired outcome."

- Discouragement and resignation are "about effort rather than outcome." Frustration "sometimes overlaps with anger": "with frustration, we don't think we can fix the situation, while with anger, we feel there is something we can do."

How this chapter builds the author's case

After chapter 2's comparison, chapter 3 turns inward to expectations. Boredom opens as a surprising source of imagination; disappointment is traced to the unspoken "movie in our mind," regret to our own choices, and the closing list sorts related experiences by control and effort. Brown's remedy is consistent: vulnerable conversation and reality-checking, and reflection rather than "no regrets."

CHAPTER 4

Places We Go When It's Beyond Us

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
Chapter 4 collects experiences that exceed what we already know: awe, wonder, confusion, curiosity, interest and surprise. They run from feeling small before something vast, to the discomfort of not understanding, to the openness that drives learning.

Awe and Wonder

- Both are "often experienced in response to nature, art, music, spiritual experiences, or ideas." We can feel "overwhelmed by the vastness of something that is almost incomprehensible." Even "a starry sky or a butterfly in the garden" can make us feel "small, but connected to each other and to the largeness itself."
- Weger and Wagemann on the difference: "Wonder inspires the wish to understand; awe inspires the wish to let shine, to acknowledge and to unite."
- Wonder "fuels our passion for exploration and learning, for curiosity and adventure." Awe "leads people to cooperate, share resources, and sacrifice for others," evoking humility; "awe-inducing events may be one of the fastest and most powerful methods of personal change and growth."

Confusion

- Her band name: "The Zone of Optimal Confusion." Confusion is an **epistemic emotion**, "an emotion critical to knowledge acquisition and learning." It "has the potential to motivate, lead to deep learning, and trigger problem solving."
- D'Mello: working through confusion means we "need to stop and think, engage in careful deliberation, develop a solution, and revise how we approach the next problem." Brown: these are "rare and courageous actions."
- Slaughter and Rock: "To be effective, learning needs to be effortful"; the key is "desirable difficulty," like a muscle that burns. "Comfortable learning environments rarely lead to deep learning."
- Too much confusion "can lead to frustration, giving up, disengagement, or even boredom."

Curiosity and Interest

- Curiosity is "an irreducible component of courageous leadership." Curiosity is "both a trait and a state"; interest "is more of a state." Curiosity involves feeling and thinking; interest "is really more about thinking."
- **Interest** "is a cognitive openness to engaging with a topic or experience." **Curiosity** "is recognizing a gap in our knowledge about something that interests us, and becoming emotionally and cognitively invested in closing that gap through exploration and learning." It "often starts with interest."
- The difference is heart and head: with interest "our mind is open to seeing what's there," with curiosity "our heart and head are both invested in closing that gap."
- Loewenstein's "information gap": curiosity is "the feeling of deprivation we experience when we identify and focus on a gap in our knowledge." We need some knowledge first; asking questions alone is not enough, so "it may be necessary to 'prime the pump'."
- "Curiosity doesn't exist without interest, but we can be interested and not have our interest grow to curiosity."
- "Choosing to be curious is choosing to be vulnerable because it requires us to surrender to uncertainty." Growing up, we turn to self-protection: "choosing certainty over curiosity, armor over vulnerability, knowing over learning."
- Einstein: "Curiosity has its own reason for existence." It "reminds us that we're alive," and correlates with "creativity, intelligence, improved learning and memory, and problem solving."

Surprise

- Defined as “an interruption caused by information that doesn’t fit with our current understanding or expectations. It causes us to reevaluate.”
- It is “a bridge between cognition and emotion,” but “a short bridge”: “the shortest-duration emotion, rarely lasting more than a few seconds.” It is also an amplifier: “more surprising events resulting in stronger emotional reactions.”
- Surprising news “is more likely to be shared,” and people return to restaurants “surprisingly better than expected.”
- “Unexpected” often “stays cognitive rather than bridging to emotion.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case
Chapter 3 dealt with plans that fail; this chapter deals with what we cannot yet grasp. Awe and wonder lead into confusion, curiosity and interest are the response, and surprise is the quick bridge from thinking to feeling.

CHAPTER 5

Places We Go When Things Aren't What They Seem

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title

Chapter 5 is about holding two things at once. Its opening asks: "What happens when we feel two competing emotions at the same time?" and "Can two seemingly contradictory thoughts both be true?" Brown answers that this push-pull "is a reflection of our complexity," and the terms that follow are amusement, bittersweet, nostalgia, cognitive dissonance, paradox, and irony and sarcasm.

Chapter opening — untitled section before the first sub-heading in the book

- "Welcome to being human! Competing emotions and contradictory thoughts are messy and can feel uncomfortable, vulnerable, even irritating." But "if we're willing to stay with it and stay curious, complexity is one of our greatest teachers."
- The problem is "when we don't have the skills or experience to tolerate the uncertainty and ambiguity and we give in to the cravings for neat, mutually exclusive categories." "There's nothing more limiting than tapping out of tension and oversimplifying the thoughts and feelings that have the power to help us understand who we are and what we need."
- Adam Grant, Think Again: "we can learn to recognize complexity as a signal of credibility," and fight "our tendency to accept binaries."
- Brown applies it to feelings: when someone says "I'm sad, but weirdly I'm also relieved," "The uncertainty feels like self-awareness to me." For someone unsure about a policy they once championed: "acknowledging uncertainty is a function of grounded confidence, and it feels like humility to me."

Amusement

- The word dates from the late 1500s, "a pleasurable diversion from work or duty." It is connected to humor and includes "unexpectedness, incongruity, and playfulness," a brief spike of cheerfulness "lasting only a few seconds." Her definition: "pleasurable, relaxed excitation."
- It differs from happiness: "happiness is a general sense of pleasure, whereas amusement appeals specifically to one's sense of humor."
- Two themes set it apart from contentment, gratitude, joy, love or pride: "An awareness of incongruity," and feeling "playful with those around us."
- At work, amusement breaks "may help replenish depleted cognitive resources."

Bittersweet

- **Bittersweet** "is a mixed feeling of happiness and sadness." Developmental milestones leave her bittersweet: proud of Ellen's new apartment, but "sad when I walk by Ellen's room"; happy about Charlie's license, sad she no longer drives him to school.
- She asked her social media followers and received "more than forty thousand" comments: watching children grow up, leaving a job, divorce, graduating, moving, death of a loved one, retiring, coming home from vacation. All share "sadness about letting go of something, mixed with happiness and/or gratitude about what's been experienced and/or what's next."
- "It's not the same as ambivalence (when we're unsure whether we're happy or sad), it's feeling both at the same time."
- At "around age seven or eight, children report experiencing positive and negative emotions simultaneously," and by ten or eleven "they can recognize and understand the tension."

Nostalgia

- "The term 'nostalgia' has a dark past." Via Adrienne Matei: in 1688 Swiss medical student Johannes Hofer coined it from nostos (homecoming) and alga (pain). It was a medical disease "until the early nineteenth century."

- Today researchers describe it as "a frequent, primarily positive, context-specific bittersweet emotion that combines elements of happiness and sadness with a sense of yearning and loss." It can help us "navigate successfully the vicissitudes of daily life," "but at what cost?"
- "Nostalgia emerged as a double-edged sword, a tool for both connection and disconnection. It can be an imaginary refuge from a world we don't understand and a dog whistle used to resist important growth in families, organizations, and the broader culture and to protect power, including white supremacy."
- What's spoken: "I wish things were the way they used to be in the good ol' days." What's not spoken: "When people knew their places." "When there was no accountability for the way my behaviors affect other people." "When my authority was absolute and never challenged."
- "Is nostalgia good, helpful, bad, dangerous, or detrimental? The answer is yes." Garrido: it can be part of healthy and unhealthy coping; for people prone to depression or rumination, it brings "negative emotional outcomes." Rumination is an "involuntary focus on negative and pessimistic thoughts"; reflection is "highly adaptive and psychologically healthy." Worry "is focused on the future, while rumination focuses on the past."
- Rumination plus nostalgia "emerged from our research as destructive and disconnecting." Every authoritarian leader will "seduce people into believing that a make-believe past could exist again, and give them someone to blame."
- Coontz: "Were the comfort and safety of that past existence real? If so, were they at someone else's expense?"
- Definition: "a yearning for the way things used to be in our often idealized and self-protective version of the past."

Cognitive Dissonance

- From Tavris and Aronson's Mistakes Were Made (but Not by Me).
- Festinger infiltrated a 1954 doomsday cult whose leader promised a flying saucer on December 20. He predicted those who had given up possessions would double down. When the spaceship was "a no-show," the leader said their faith had spared the world, and the most invested "became even more invested evangelists."
- Tavris and Aronson: "Cognitive dissonance is a state of tension that occurs when a person holds two cognitions (ideas, attitudes, beliefs, opinions) that are psychologically inconsistent with each other, such as 'Smoking is a dumb thing to do because it could kill me' and 'I smoke two packs a day.'" People "don't rest easy until they find a way to reduce it."
- Faced with challenging information, we resolve dissonance by "rejecting the new information, decreasing its importance, or avoiding it altogether." "The greater the magnitude of the dissonance, the greater is the pressure to reduce dissonance."
- Brown: "we need to stay curious and resist choosing comfort over courage. It's brave to invite new information to the table, to sit with it and hear it out." Grant: "the ability to rethink and unlearn."

Paradox

- Cognitive dissonance pushes us to resolve tension; "paradox challenges us to straddle the tension of two conflicting elements and recognize that they can both be true." Latin paradoxum means "seemingly absurd but really true."
- "A paradox is the appearance of contradiction between two related components." Like light and darkness, they are "inextricably linked" and "complement and inform each other."
- Her example: "Vulnerability is the first thing we look for in other people, and the last thing we want to show them about ourselves." Digging in reveals: "Vulnerability is courage in you and inadequacy in me." "I'm drawn to your vulnerability but repelled by mine."
- "Paradox is not an emotion." It starts with thinking, then emotion as we feel the tension. It cannot be resolved by logic: "we need to allow the seeming contradictions to coexist in order to gain deeper understanding."

- Collins: “False dichotomies are undisciplined thought.” Builders of greatness avoid the “Tyranny of the OR” for the “Genius of the AND” (Creativity AND Discipline; Humility AND Audacity). Rejecting paradox “can result in conflict and turmoil”; accepting it “can foster creativity, innovation, and productivity.” “Paradoxes: hard and good.”

Irony and Sarcasm

- Both are forms of communication in which “the literal meaning of the words is different, often opposite, from the intended message.” However, “sarcasm is a particular type of irony in which the underlying message is normally meant to ridicule, tease, or criticize.”
- Both are “easily misunderstood,” especially with strangers, heightened emotion, or “emailing or texting.”
- Developmentally, “children do not seem to distinguish between irony and sarcasm until the age of nine or ten.”
- Her family confused sarcasm “with intellectual ability and craft,” and it often went too far. “Sarcasm” comes from a Greek word meaning “to tear flesh.” She and Steve set an intention to watch it with the kids. With her friend Chaz, it is “reserved for playfulness only.”
- Her watch-out: “Are you dressing something up in humor that actually requires clarity and honesty?”

How this chapter builds the author’s case

Chapter 4 ended with surprise, a bridge between thinking and feeling. Chapter 5 asks what to do with mixed or contradictory feelings and ideas, sorting them by whether we resolve the tension (dissonance), live inside it (bittersweet, paradox), or hide in it (nostalgia, sarcasm). The thread is the opening claim: complexity “is one of our greatest teachers.”

CHAPTER 6

Places We Go When We're Hurting

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
Chapter 6 names the experiences of deep hurt: anguish, hopelessness, despair, sadness and grief. It starts with the most acute (anguish), moves to hope and the loss of it, then to sadness, and ends with grief as an ongoing process that needs witnesses more than fixes.

Anguish

- Poets and artists "approach the topic of anguish without apology," leaving "a sense of shock, heartbreak, and foreboding."
- Social scientists "seem to steer clear of the concept of anguish altogether." Yet "anguish is an emotion and an experience that is singular and must be understood and named, especially for those of us who have experienced it, will experience it, or may bear witness to it."
- Definition: **anguish** is "an almost unbearable and traumatic swirl of shock, incredulity, grief, and powerlessness." Together they take "our ability to breathe, feel, and think—it comes for our bones." Anguish "often causes us to physically crumple in on ourselves."
- "The element of powerlessness is what makes anguish traumatic. We are unable to change, reverse, or negotiate what has happened."
- Her example: a call from someone she loves, who disclosed "a major trauma that I did not know about." "I dropped my purse so I could brace myself against the wall." "Pure anguish." After months of "desperate attempts to fix, change, and help, followed by more anguish," she got help.
- A decade later she no longer falls to the ground, "but it still evokes anguish and I am not the same." It "took time and help and processing for the bones to come back, and they're slightly different than they were before."
- Second example, from graduate student Gabriella: her friend Carmen, whose mother died of cancer when she was twelve, was about to have her quinceañera. Her father handed her an envelope: "Your mother wrote you this note the week before she died." Carmen "immediately fell to the floor"; Gabi said, "She just sank. And moaned." Her siblings and father ended up on the floor too.
- The lesson: "a grief we've come to know and understand and even integrate into our lives—can surprise us again and again, often in the form of anguish," especially when something sparks shock and incredulity.
- Without support "we go through the motions, but we are still crumpled." The alternative is to hang the "crumpling anguish on rigidity and perfectionism and silence, like a wet towel hanging on a rod," becoming "closed off, never open to vulnerability and its gifts."
- "The human spirit is resilient," and "we can rebuild the bones that anguish rips away. But it takes help and time."
- Suse Ellen Lowenstein's Dark Elegy: her son Alexander was murdered on Pan Am flight 103 over Lockerbie. The memorial has 75 pieces, each portraying a mother or wife "at that moment when they first heard the awful news," and was "created by one of those affected rather than by an outsider."

Hope, Hopelessness, and Despair

- "We need hope like we need air." But "hope is not what most of us think it is. It's not a warm, fuzzy emotion." It "is a way of thinking—a cognitive process," made of what C. R. Snyder called a "trilogy of goals, pathways, and agency."
- We experience **hope** when we can set realistic goals ("I know where I want to go"), figure out how to reach them while staying flexible and tolerating disappointment ("I know how to get there, I'm persistent"), and have agency ("I can do this!").
- "Hope is a function of struggle—we develop hope not during the easy or comfortable times, but through adversity and discomfort." Yet "It doesn't matter how much hope we have if the deck is stacked or the rules apply to some but not others."

- "Hope is learned." Per Snyder, children learn it from parents, in relationships "characterized by boundaries, consistency, and support." Hopeful children have been given "the opportunity to struggle."
- Her reminder: "Prepare the child for the path, not the path for the child."

Hopelessness and Despair

- "Everything about these words is hard." "While hope is not an emotion, hopelessness and despair are emotions." Hopelessness "arises out of a combination of negative life events and negative thought patterns, particularly self-blame and the perceived inability to change our circumstances."
- Reversing Snyder: we cannot set realistic goals ("we don't know what we want"), cannot figure out how to achieve them, "give up when we fail," and "don't believe in ourselves."
- "Hopelessness is serious." Aaron Beck and colleagues established over thirty years that it is "strongly and specifically related to suicidality."
- **Despair** "is a sense of hopelessness about a person's entire life and future," when "extreme hopelessness seeps into all the corners of our lives and combines with extreme sadness." Rob Bell: "the belief that tomorrow will be just like today."
- Hope practices: reality-check goals and pathways and "take the shame out of having to start over many, many times." As a professor she expected "90 percent of the goals to be unrealistic." "Setting realistic goals is a skill and a prerequisite for hope."
- Seligman's 3 Ps. **Personalization**: we believe "we are the problem"; "Self-blame and criticism don't lead to increased hopefulness; they're quicksand." **Permanence**: the "Tomorrow will be no different from today" thinking. Her habit: will this "be a big deal in five minutes? Five hours? Five days? Five months? Five years?" It "pulls my thinking brain online instead of letting my fear brain run the show." **Pervasiveness**: believing the problem "has stained or changed every single thing in our life." A work crisis felt like "the end of the world," then a text: "hey mom do you know where my new goggles are?"

Sadness

- Asked their favorite sad movie, her community sent "more than a hundred thousand enthusiastic responses." Reasons: "Beautifully devastating," "I felt less alone," "When I need a good cry."
- "I'm not going to tell you that sadness is wonderful and we need it. I'm going to say that sadness is important and we need it." It "is a normal response to loss or defeat, or even the perception of loss or defeat." "Owning our sadness is courageous."
- Four things to know. 1. Sadness and depression are not the same: depression "is a cluster of symptoms that persist over a period of time." 2. Sadness and grief are not the same: sadness "is one part of grief."
- 3. Sadness has positive aspects. Forgas: "Sad people are less prone to judgmental errors," and "can act with more generosity, too." "Don't haphazardly push away your sadness. No doubt, it's there for good reason."
- Her research: "acknowledging and naming our own sadness is critical in the formation of compassion and empathy." In our saddest moments "we want to be held by or feel connected to someone who has known that same ache."
- 4. There is a reason we love sad movies. Hanich and colleagues studied the sad-film paradox: "We like to be moved." "Sadness moves the individual 'us' toward the collective 'us.'" Sadness leads to feeling moved, which leads to enjoyment; it is "a contributor to and intensifier of the emotional state of being moved."

Grief

- Grief is "a process that includes many emotions, rather than a singular emotion." Recent research "refutes the idea that grief progresses in predictable, sequenced stages."
- Neimeyer: "A central process in grieving is the attempt to reaffirm or reconstruct a world of meaning that has been challenged by loss."

- Three foundational elements from her data. **Loss** includes harder-to-name losses: “the loss of normality, the loss of what could be, and the loss of what we thought we knew.” **Longing** “is not conscious wanting; it’s an involuntary yearning for wholeness, for understanding, for meaning.” **Feeling lost**: grief “requires us to reorient every part of our physical, emotional, and social worlds.”
- “The more difficult it is for us to articulate” these, “the more disconnected and alone we feel,” in a world that wants us to “get over it.”
- Columbia’s Center for Complicated Grief: “When a person adapts to a loss grief is not over.” It means “grief finds a place” in our lives; she imagines honoring that place “rather than hiding it, ignoring it, or pretending it doesn’t exist.”
- David Kessler: “Each person’s grief is as unique as their fingerprint.” Everyone needs it witnessed, “someone to be fully present to the magnitude of their loss without trying to point out the silver lining.” Neimeyer: people want someone “who can join them in making sense of the death without withdrawing into awkward silence.”

The Center for Complicated Grief

- **Acute grief** occurs in the initial period after a loss, with “strong feelings of yearning, longing, and sadness along with anxiety, bitterness, anger, remorse, guilt, and/or shame.” It “dominates a person’s life.”
- **Integrated grief** “is the result of adaptation to the loss.” Feelings are “integrated in ways that allow them to remember and honor the person who died.”
- **Complicated grief** “occurs when something interferes with adaptation.” Acute grief “can persist for very long periods,” they “don’t see a pathway forward,” and It needs “a mental health professional with training in complicated grief work.”

Based on the research of Tashel Bordere

- **Disenfranchised grief** is grief that “is not openly acknowledged or publicly supported through mourning practices or rituals because the experience is not valued or counted [by others] as a loss.” Examples: divorce, “loss of an unborn child and/or infertility,” loss of a loved one to suicide, and the many losses of a sexual assault survivor, such as “loss of trust” and “loss of a sense of safety and security.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case

Chapter 5 held contradictory feelings together; chapter 6 names those that hurt most. It runs from the shock of anguish, through the loss of hope, to the ordinary sadness and long process of grief. Each ends in the same need: someone to be present to the pain, and the skill to name it rather than outrun it.

CHAPTER 7

Places We Go with Others

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
Chapter 7 turns from our inner states to our responses to other people's pain. It asks "What's the most effective way to be in connection with and in service to someone who is struggling, without taking on their issues as our own?" The terms are compassion, pity, empathy, sympathy, boundaries and comparative suffering. Pity and sympathy are presented as the "near enemies" of compassion and empathy.

Compassion and Empathy

- The debate is "frustratingly hijacked on occasion by folks who come up with new, arbitrary definitions for emotions" and then argue the emotion is "bad."
- "When it comes to language, I'm a populist. How we, the collective, use language matters as much as, if not more than, arbitrary definitions that don't center lived experiences."

The Relationship Between Compassion and Empathy

- "Compassion is a daily practice and empathy is a skill set that is one of the most powerful tools of compassion." The most effective approach "combines compassion with a specific type of empathy called cognitive empathy."
- **Compassion** "is the daily practice of recognizing and accepting our shared humanity so that we treat ourselves and others with loving-kindness, and we take action in the face of suffering." It is "not just feeling, it's doing."
- It is "fueled by understanding and accepting that we're all made of strength and struggle—no one is immune to pain or suffering." It is not "'better than' or 'I can fix you'."
- Pema Chödrön: "Compassion is not a relationship between the healer and the wounded. It's a relationship between equals. Only when we know our own darkness well can we be present with the darkness of others."
- This "completely rearranged my parenting approach." She went from "always wanting to fix things" to "literally sitting in the dark with my kids." It is "still really hard": "Everything in my body is screaming, 'Make it better! Fix it!'"

Pity

- "While compassion is not rescuing, it's also not pity. In fact, pity is the near enemy of compassion." Neff: a **near enemy** is "a state of mind that appears similar to the desired state—hence it is 'near'—but actually undermines it." Near enemies are often "greater threats than far enemies because they're more difficult to recognize."
- Kornfield: pity says "Oh, that poor person." It "sees them as different from ourselves" and sets up "a sense of distance and remoteness from the suffering of others that is affirming and gratifying to the self." Compassion recognizes "I understand this; I suffer in the same way." "Compassion is shared suffering."
- "There's nothing worse than feeling pitied." Pity involves four elements: "a belief that the suffering person is inferior; a passive, self-focused reaction that does not include providing help; a desire to maintain emotional distance; and avoidance of sharing in the other person's suffering."
- Kornfield: "Compassion does not mean immersing ourselves in the suffering of others to the point of anguish."

Empathy

- **Empathy** is "an emotional skill set that allows us to understand what someone is experiencing and to reflect back that understanding."

- **Cognitive empathy** is "the ability to recognize and understand another person's emotions." **Affective empathy** is "one's own emotional attunement with another person's experience." She believes "meaningful connection requires a combination of compassion and cognitive empathy."
- Empathy is "understanding what someone is feeling, not feeling it for them." If someone is lonely, we only "reach back into our own experience with loneliness." Affective empathy "is a slippery slope toward becoming overwhelmed and not being able to offer meaningful support."
- Theresa Wiseman's attributes: perspective taking; "Staying out of judgment: Just listen, don't put value on it"; recognizing emotion; communicating our understanding, sometimes simply "Shit. That's hard. I get that."; and, from Neff, practicing mindfulness.
- "We can respond empathically only if we are willing to be present to someone's pain."
- Leveraging someone's emotions is not empathy: "We should call that manipulation or exploitation. Language matters."

Sympathy

- "Empathy is not sympathy." Sympathy is the near enemy of empathy, "a form of disconnection." Someone who says "I feel sorry for you" is "standing at a safe distance." Rather than "me too," it communicates "not me."
- "Sympathy and pity are first cousins." Lulu Wang: "The difference is hierarchy."
- Dispel the myth that empathy is "walking in someone else's shoes": "I need to learn how to listen to the story you tell about what it's like in your shoes and believe you even when it doesn't match my experiences."
- "Compassion fatigue" occurs when caregivers focus "on their own personal distress reaction"; a better term may be "empathic distress fatigue." "We're not hearing the story, we're inserting ourselves in the story."
- The top question: "How can I be empathic with someone if I haven't had their experience?" "Empathy is not relating to an experience, it's connecting to what someone is feeling about an experience." Anyone who knows joy, hurt, heartbreak or grief: "You're qualified."

EMPATHY MISSES

- Eight responses that fail. **Sympathy** versus empathy: "I feel sorry for you"; the subtext is distance, "Oh, you poor thing" or "Bless your heart." **Judgment**: "You 'should' feel shame!" **Disappointment**: "You've let me down." **Discharging discomfort with blame**: "What were you thinking?" **Minimize/avoid**: "You're exaggerating." **Comparing/competing**: "That's nothing."
- **Speaking truth to power**: "I can't believe you said that to your boss!" **Advice giving/problem solving**: "rather than listen and be with people in their emotion, we start fixing."

Boundaries

- "Boundaries are a prerequisite for compassion and empathy. We can't connect with someone unless we're clear about where we end and they begin." Without autonomy "there's no compassion or empathy, just enmeshment."
- From The Gifts of Imperfection: "If we really want to practice compassion, we have to start by setting boundaries and holding people accountable for their behavior."
- Before understanding this she was "much sweeter but less authentic." Now "kinder and less judgmental. But also firmer and more solid. Occasionally salty."
- Kelly Rae Roberts's blog post "What's OK and What's Not OK" about her art is a model. "Clear is kind. Unclear is unkind." We forget the "what is okay" part, e.g. "It's okay to be pissed. It's not okay to raise your voice and pound on the table."

Comparative Suffering

- “Empathy is not finite, and compassion is not a pizza with eight slices.” Practicing them means “There’s more.” “But fear and scarcity trigger comparison, and even pain and hurt are not immune to being assessed and ranked.”
- In COVID: “My husband died, and that grief is worse than your grief over missing your daughter’s wedding.” The family in India “doesn’t benefit more if you conserve your concern only for them.”
- “Perspective is critical,” but “Hurt is hurt, and every time we honor our own struggle and the struggles of others by responding with empathy and compassion, the healing that results affects all of us.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case
Chapter 6 described pain in ourselves; chapter 7 describes how to meet pain in others. The sequence is compassion as the practice, empathy as its tool, pity and sympathy as their near enemies, boundaries as the precondition, and comparative suffering as a scarcity trap.

CHAPTER 8

Places We Go When We Fall Short

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
Chapter 8 separates four experiences we have a tendency to "use them interchangeably": shame, guilt, humiliation and embarrassment, "very different in terms of biology, biography, behavior, backstory, and self-talk," with "radically different outcomes." Brown adds the role of self-compassion and says perfectionism "is a function of shame." Her opening notes that new research on humiliation and violence "completely changed the way I think about that emotion."

Chapter opening — untitled section before the first sub-heading in the book

- A quote opens the chapter: "Science is not the truth. Science is finding the truth. When science changes its opinion, it didn't lie to you. It learned more." After twenty years nothing had shifted her thinking "until recently," and new research "reinforced my belief that shame and humiliation will never be effective social justice tools."
- Short definitions, using an F on a quiz. **Shame**: "I am bad. The focus is on self, not behavior." Result: "feeling flawed and unworthy of love, belonging, and connection." "Shame is not a driver of positive change."
- **Guilt**: "I did something bad. The focus is on behavior." It is "the discomfort we feel when we evaluate what we've done or failed to do against our values" and "can drive positive change and behavior."
- **Humiliation**: "I've been belittled and put down by someone." "With shame, we believe that we deserve our sense of unworthiness. With humiliation, we don't feel we deserve it." You feel "dumb and enraged."
- **Embarrassment**: "I did something that made me uncomfortable, but I know I'm not alone." It is "fleeting, sometimes funny," like toilet paper stuck to your shoe.

Shame

- Antwone Fisher's Finding Fish was "a Sliding Doors moment" when she began and got "pushback from every direction." Her "shame 1-2-3s": "We all have it." "We're all afraid to talk about it." "The less we talk about it, the more control it has over us. Shame hates being spoken."
- Participants' examples include "Shame is bankruptcy" and "Shame is infertility."
- "Shame is the fear of disconnection." "I'm unlovable. I don't belong."
- Definition: "Shame is the intensely painful feeling or experience of believing that we are flawed and therefore unworthy of love, belonging, and connection." It "thrives on secrecy, silence, and judgment" and in a petri dish "will grow exponentially into every corner and crevice of our lives."
- "The antidote to shame is empathy." "Shame needs you to believe that you're alone. Empathy is a hostile environment for shame."
- "Shame is a social emotion. Shame happens between people and it heals between people." Self-compassion "is often the first step to healing shame—we need to be kind to ourselves before we can share our stories with someone else."
- Neff's three elements of self-compassion: **self-kindness** vs. self-judgment, **common humanity** vs. isolation, **mindfulness** vs. over-identification. Self-kindness means "being warm and understanding toward ourselves when we suffer, fail, or feel inadequate." Mindfulness: "We cannot ignore our pain and feel compassion for it at the same time."
- Her growth area is self-kindness: "I talk to myself in ways that I would never talk to people I love." "Self-kindness is both more difficult and more revolutionary than we think."

The Four Elements of Shame Resilience

- Participants who moved through shame "without sacrificing their values and authenticity" shared four practices, which "rarely happen in this order—they just all need to happen."
- **Recognizing shame and understanding its triggers**: "Can you physically recognize when you're in the grip of shame, name it, feel your way through it?" **Practicing critical awareness**: reality-check the

messages and expectations driving shame. **Reaching out**: "We can't experience empathy if we're not connecting." **Speaking shame**: "Silence, secrecy, and judgment fuel shame."

Shame in Culture

- Calling people "shameless" is "wrong and dangerous." From Dare to Lead: "Shame isn't the cure, it's the cause." Narcissism is "the shame-based fear of being ordinary." Such people need "More accountability for their behavior and lack of empathy? Yes. More shame just makes them more dangerous."
- "Shame is not a compass for moral behavior." Where shame exists, "empathy is almost always absent." The problem is "people being empathyless, not shameless."
- Ronda Dearing: empathy "draws our attention outward"; shame "draws our focus inward." "Shame and empathy are incompatible."

Perfectionism

- "Shame is the birthplace of perfectionism." Not "striving to be our best." "Healthy striving is internally driven. Perfectionism is externally driven by a simple but potentially all-consuming question: What will people think?"
- It blocks mastery: "Perfectionism kills curiosity by telling us that we have to know everything or we risk looking 'less than.'" Perfectionists "Feel socially disconnected and have fewer social connections."
- Definition: "a self-destructive and addictive belief system that fuels this primary thought: If I look perfect, live perfectly, work perfectly, and do everything perfectly, I can avoid or minimize the painful feelings of shame, judgment, and blame." It is "not self-improvement"; it is "about trying to earn approval and acceptance."
- The belief: "I am what I accomplish and how well I accomplish it. Please. Perform. Perfect." Healthy striving asks "How can I improve?"; perfectionism asks "What will they think?"
- It "often sets you on the path to depression, anxiety, addiction, and life paralysis," meaning "all of the opportunities we miss because we're too afraid to put anything out in the world that could be imperfect." It is "a twenty-ton shield that we lug around."
- Self-destructive because "there is no such thing as perfection." Addictive because when shame comes, "we often believe it's because we weren't perfect enough," so we become "even more entrenched."

Guilt

- Like shame, guilt arises when we fall short, but "our focus is on having done something wrong and on doing something to set things right, like apologizing or changing a behavior." **Remorse**, "a subset of guilt," is feeling bad about harm and wanting "to atone."
- Shame is "highly correlated with addiction, violence, aggression, depression, eating disorders, and bullying"; guilt "is negatively correlated." "Empathy and guilt work together to create a force that is adaptive and powerful."
- Guilt is "a psychologically uncomfortable feeling, but one that's helpful." "Shame, however, corrodes the very part of us that believes we can change and do better."

Humiliation

- Annan: "All the cruel and brutal things, even genocide, start with the humiliation of one individual."
- Definition: "the intensely painful feeling that we've been unjustly degraded, ridiculed, or put down and that our identity has been demeaned or devalued." Like shame we feel flawed, but "someone else pointed out our flaws, and we don't feel we deserved it." "When it happens to us, it feels unjust."
- She used to think humiliation "less dangerous" than shame. Then Harter's 2003 report on ten school shooters found "in every case, the shooters described how they had been ridiculed, taunted, teased, harassed or bullied."

- Elison and Harter: “bullying alone does not lead to aggression.” People become violent “specifically when feelings of humiliation accompany the bullying.”
- Hartling: humiliation can trigger social pain and decreased self-regulation that lead to violence; it may be “perhaps the most toxic social dynamic of our age.”
- “Shame and humiliation will never be effective social justice tools. They are tools of oppression.” Wiesel: “Never allow anyone to be humiliated in your presence.”

Embarrassment

- “A fleeting feeling of self-conscious discomfort in response to a minor incident that was witnessed by others.” We can see it as “kind of funny and something that could have happened to anyone.” Miller: it lasts “only a few minutes instead of hours or days,” marked by the blush.
- Three triggers: “Committing a faux pas or social mistake,” “Being the center of attention,” and “Being in a sticky social situation.” Secondhand embarrassment “is real,” as when Lucy and Ethel work the chocolate conveyor belt.
- “Embarrassment takes years to develop, and its emergence coincides with the self-conscious ability to understand what others may be thinking of us.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case
After chapter 7’s compassion and empathy, chapter 8 shows what happens when we fall short and cannot extend them to ourselves. It sorts four easily confused experiences by their focus (self or behavior), then names the antidote (empathy, with self-compassion) and the shield (perfectionism).

CHAPTER 9

Places We Go When We Search for Connection

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
Chapter 9 gathers the experiences around our basic need to be with others: belonging and fitting in, connection and disconnection, insecurity, invisibility and loneliness. It follows chapter 8's shame, which chapter 8 defined as the fear of disconnection. It opens with belonging as the need, then names what breaks it, and ends with loneliness as the warning sign that we need connection.

Belonging and Fitting In

- Epigraph: "We have to belong to ourselves as much as we need to belong to others. Any belonging that asks us to betray ourselves is not true belonging."
- "Love and belonging are irreducible needs for all people. In the absence of love and belonging, there is always suffering." Why: "we are a social species. We can't survive without one another."
- "The topic of belonging always emerged in the data." You keep "bumping into belonging—it's just too primal." As a grounded theory researcher her job is to understand "the main concern" of participants.
- Her finding: "We want to be a part of something—to experience real connection with others—but not at the cost of their authenticity, freedom, or power." Participants described "a diminishing sense of shared humanity" and feared the only thing binding us is "shared fear and disdain, not common humanity, shared trust, respect, or love."
- Counterintuitive: "connection to a larger humanity gives people more freedom to express their individuality without fear of jeopardizing belonging." And: "True belonging doesn't require us to change who we are; it requires us to be who we are."
- Our yearning is "so hardwired" that we try to get belonging by fitting in and "hustling for approval and acceptance." These are "hollow substitutes for belonging, but they are the greatest barriers to belonging." When we fit in, "our 'belonging' is tenuous"; if we step outside the group's rules, "we risk everything." If people don't know who we are, "there's no true belonging."
- "Our sense of belonging can never be greater than our level of self-acceptance." We can never belong "if we are betraying ourselves, our ideals, or our values." Belonging is not passive: "Belonging is a practice that requires us to be vulnerable, get uncomfortable, and learn how to be present with people without sacrificing who we are." Sacrificing ourselves leaves us "disconnected from ourselves."
- Her own story: she "never felt like I belonged in my family," an introvert where "introversion was mistaken for weakness and extroversion for confidence." Nothing was normalized, so "I thought something was wrong with me."
- As a parent her goal is to help her children "believe in and belong to themselves," and know "they always belong at home." Pressure to fit in is "real and unrelenting," but inextricable connection is "a fierce protector." "Be here. Be you. Belong."

Belonging Uncertainty

- **Belonging uncertainty** is "the term sometimes used to describe questioning one's social belongingness." It "can be high among members of marginalized groups,", harming "motivation and achievement" among underrepresented students.
- "Belonging is not about the number of friends one has in a space." Walton and Brady: "a more general inference, drawn from cues, events, experiences, and relationships, about the quality of fit or potential fit between oneself and a setting."
- Paola Sánchez Valdez, the organization's first postgraduate social work fellow, tells her story. At ten, watching the 2006 immigration protests, "I learned I was undocumented." After fifteen years undocumented, DACA let her "come out of the shadows," but "the trauma that came from living most of my life in limbo followed me into college." She told a friend who was also undocumented, and they created a student advocacy organization at UVA.

- The saying “ni de aquí, ni de allá” means “not from here, not from there.” Her conclusion: “I don’t know if I’ll ever feel like I belong to this country or another, but what I do know is that I belong to myself.”

Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Belonging

- Epigraph from Tarana Burke: “I don’t believe your antiracist work is complete or valid or useful if you haven’t engaged with Black humanity.”
- In Dare to Lead work belonging is “a critical component” of DEI, so they say **DEIB** and call their position statement the Belonging Statement. People should feel belonging and shape culture “through representation, co-creation, influence, and that inextricable, unnamable, spiritual connection that is shared humanity. Anything less is not enough.”

Connection and Disconnection

- She found Relational-Cultural Theory (RCT) from the Stone Center at Wellesley, built from lived experience: “It felt like home.” Jordan: “The need for connection in which growth is a priority is the core motivation in people’s lives.” Research: “people who have strong connections with others are happier, healthier, and better able to cope with the stresses of everyday life.”
- Definition: she defines **connection** as “the energy that exists between people when they feel seen, heard, and valued; when they can give and receive without judgment; and when they derive sustenance and strength from the relationship.”
- “Connection is in our neurobiology.” So disconnection is painful, and chronic disconnection leads to “social isolation, loneliness, and feelings of powerlessness.”
- Jordan: “RCT sees disconnections as normative and inevitable in relationships; they occur when one person misunderstands, invalidates, excludes, humiliates, or injures the other person in some way.” If addressed and reworked, “they become places of enormous growth.” Unaddressed, in unequal power structures, the person “often loses touch with [their] own feelings and inner experience.” Brown: “disconnection from another person can create disconnection within ourselves.”
- “I think we underestimate how much disconnection hurts. And it hurts more than our feelings. It can cause physical pain.” Rejection, exclusion and isolation “share the same neural pathways with feelings of physical pain.”
- Watch-out one, Raque-Bogdan: individuals “may enact their own disconnection strategies, such as hiding parts of themselves or discounting their need for others.” Brown: “it’s a recipe for loneliness and, for me, blame.” “It’s a lot of scrambling to avoid being hurt. And it doesn’t even work.”
- Watch-out two: the “perfectionism social disconnection model” shows perfectionists “behave in ways that cause perceived and actual exclusion/rejection by others.” Brown: “my perfectionism drives me to show up in ways that lead people to push me away.”
- The symmetry: “Authenticity is a requirement for belonging, and fitting in is a threat.” “Authenticity is a requirement for connection, and perfectionism (a type of fitting in) is a threat.”

Insecurity

- We say “insecure” often, normally for “self-doubt or a lack of confidence, but there’s way more to it.” Three types:
- **Domain-specific insecurity**: insecure about a specific domain or resource, such as food, finances or physical safety. “Combating domain-specific insecurity is about access and resources.”
- **Relationship or interpersonal insecurity**: we don’t feel “a supportive and trusting relationship,” in one relationship or all. It makes us “uncertain about being loved, trusted, protected, and valued.”
- **General or personal insecurity**: being “overly critical of our weaknesses,” such as body image or work performance.
- Huang and Berenbaum: the opposite is **self-security**, “the open and nonjudgmental acceptance of one’s own weaknesses.” We can have high self-esteem and still feel insecure “if we’re self-critical. That is powerful.” Secure people are “more willing to be vulnerable with others.”

- Brown's takeaway: "Without awareness, our fear of being hurt can push us to show up in ways that increase the certainty that we'll be hurt."

Invisibility

- "Given that we are all here to be seen, known, and loved, invisibility is one of the most painful human experiences."
- Definition: "I define invisibility as a function of disconnection and dehumanization, where an individual or group's humanity and relevance are unacknowledged, ignored, and/or diminished in value or importance."
- "Invisibility is its own form of stigmatization." Marginalized people are caught "in an ever-tightening vise of two types of dehumanization—stereotyping and invisibility."

Loneliness

- She researched loneliness for over a year for Braving the Wilderness. John Cacioppo, founder of social neuroscience, and William Patrick defined it as "perceived social isolation." At its heart is "the absence of meaningful social interaction."
- "Loneliness and being alone are very different things." Solitude "can be a powerful and healing thing"; as an introvert, "I often feel the loneliest when I'm with other people."
- Loneliness is a warning like hunger, thirst and pain; it "tells us that we need social connection—something as critical to our well-being as food and water." "Denying you feel lonely makes no more sense than denying you feel hungry."
- Yet we feel shame, "as if feeling lonely means there's something wrong with us," even when caused by grief, loss or heartbreak.
- It is "not just a sad condition—it's a dangerous one." The brain goes into self-preservation mode: "less empathy, more defensiveness, more numbing, and less sleeping." "Unchecked loneliness fuels continued loneliness by keeping us afraid to reach out."
- Our response should be to find connection, which doesn't mean many groups: "it's not the quantity of friends but the quality of a few relationships that actually matters."
- Holt-Lunstad, Smith and Layton's meta-analysis: air pollution raises odds of dying early 5 percent, obesity 20, excessive drinking 30, and loneliness "45 percent."

How this chapter builds the author's case
Chapter 8 ended with shame and perfectionism. Chapter 9 shows what they cost: false belonging (fitting in), disconnection, insecurity, invisibility and loneliness. Brown's repeated test is authenticity: fitting in threatens belonging, perfectionism threatens connection, and connection is what the whole atlas serves.

CHAPTER 10

Places We Go When the Heart Is Open

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
Chapter 10 collects what happens when we open ourselves to others: love, lovelessness, heartbreak, trust, self-trust, betrayal, defensiveness, flooding and hurt. It begins with love, then heartbreak (the price of love), then trust and its violation, and ends with the reactions (defensiveness, flooding) and the brave sentence "My feelings are hurt."

Love

- Fredrickson's umbrella term love includes "the preoccupying and strong desire for further connection, the powerful bonds people hold with a select few and the intimacy that grows between them, the commitments to loyalty and faithfulness."
- Researchers debate whether love is an emotion, but "among everyone else, love is clearly thought of as an emotion." In Shaver's study of 213 words, "love" got the highest average rating (3.94), "edging out the word 'hate' (3.90)."
- A definition emerged and "withstood the test of new data": "We cultivate love when we allow our most vulnerable and powerful selves to be deeply seen and known, and when we honor the spiritual connection that grows from that offering with trust, respect, kindness, and affection."
- "Love is not something we give or get; it is something that we nurture and grow, a connection that can be cultivated between two people only when it exists within each one of them—we can love others only as much as we love ourselves."
- "Shame, blame, disrespect, betrayal, and the withholding of affection damage the roots from which love grows. Love can survive these injuries only if they're acknowledged, healed, and rare."

Lovelessness

- bell hooks teaches that injustice and systemic oppression "stem from a deep, collective lovelessness" and calls for an ethic of love. "A love ethic is a rigorous calling."
- Brown: "I don't want to betray my mind or heart. I want to live by a love ethic. We need more love between us, but also among us. Not rainbow and unicorn love, or commercialized love. We need more real love. Gritty, dangerous, wild-eyed, justice-seeking love."

Heartbreak

- She researched it for Rising Strong: heartbreak "is always connected to love and belonging," so it hurts in a different way than disappointment or failure.
- Joe Reynolds, a retired Episcopal priest, taught her most: "Disappointment doesn't grow into heartbreak, nor does failure. Heartbreak comes from the loss of love or the perceived loss of love." "Heartbreak is what happens when love is lost."
- Forms: rejection by the one you love (and "Unrequited love can be heartbreaking"); death, which is "nobody's fault" yet "my heart is broken anyway"; the death of "something unique, maybe even essential, in someone I love," like a child's innocence, and non-permanent loss: "Moving away from a loved one can break your heart." "The common denominator is the loss of love or the perceived loss of love."
- "To love with any level of intensity and honesty is to become vulnerable." "To love is to know the loss of love. Heartbreak is unavoidable unless we choose not to love at all. A lot of people do just that."
- Airport story: a weeping woman said, "We had to put our dog down. My heart is broken." Brown thought "I don't think a dog would be worth heartbreak." Years later her dog Daisy died of cancer. The family sobbed: "We loved Daisy so much. This is heartbreak." Her thought: "God, this hurts. And it's totally worth it. The brokenhearted are the bravest among us—they dared to love."

Trust

- Charles Feltman (The Thin Book of Trust) defines trust as "choosing to risk making something you value vulnerable to another person's actions."
- "Trust is more of a cognitive assessment than an emotion," but talking about it stirs "hurt and defensiveness." "If someone says 'I don't trust you,' it feels like a general assault on our character." Seven elements emerged; the acronym is **BRAVING**:
- **Boundaries**: "You respect my boundaries." **Reliability**: "You do what you say you'll do." **Vault**: "You don't share information or experiences that are not yours to share." **Nonjudgment**: I can ask for what I need without judgment.
- **Accountability**: "You own your mistakes, apologize, and make amends."
- **Integrity**: "You choose courage over comfort. You choose what is right over what is fun, fast, or easy. And you choose to practice your values rather than simply professing them."
- **Generosity**: "You extend the most generous interpretation possible to the intentions, words, and actions of others."
- Self-trust "is normally the first casualty of failure or mistakes." We stop trusting ourselves "when we hurt others, get hurt, feel shame, or question our worth." After twenty-five years of sobriety she can "trust myself and my actions when it comes to protecting what I value." BRAVING applies inward, ending: Did I act from my integrity? Was I generous toward myself?

Betrayal

- Betrayal is painful because "it is a violation of trust"; it can feel "as if the ground beneath us has given way." Abuse by a trusted partner or family member is **betrayal trauma**. Effects include anxiety, depression, "decreased self-worth," shame and trauma symptoms.
- Self-betrayal: saying something she didn't believe "in order to avoid feeling left out." "The harshest consequence of that for me was dealing with my own betrayal."
- **Institutional betrayal** occurs when "an institution causes harm [by action or inaction] to an individual who trusts or depends upon that institution."
- The most devastating is a cover-up, perpetrated "by a culture of complicity and shame." When protecting a system's reputation outranks "the basic human dignity of individuals or communities," expect "Shame is systemic," "Accountability is dead," and "a trail of devastation and pain."
- Healing is rare: "the only way back from betrayal is accountability, amends, and action," which require acknowledging the pain "without rationalizing or making excuses." We are "much better … at shaming and blaming than we are at actual accountability."

Defensiveness

- "At its core, defensiveness is a way to protect our ego and a fragile self-esteem." Ellen Alley: self-esteem is fragile when failures and imperfections decrease self-worth. The opposite is **grounded confidence**: "we accept our imperfections and they don't diminish our self-worth." Any perceived call-out of weakness "is experienced as an attack on our worth," so we get defensive; it "blocks us from hearing feedback."
- Physical cues: "Folding their arms over their chest," tunnel vision, racing heart. Brown's strategy: "subtly open my palms" and say, "I'm sorry. Can you say that again? I really want to understand."

Flooding

- The Gottman Institute: flooding is "a sensation of feeling psychologically and physically overwhelmed during conflict, making it virtually impossible to have a productive, problem-solving discussion." Gottman: a "built-in meter" measures accumulating negativity; "When the level gets too high for you, the needle starts going haywire and flooding begins."
- Her family pattern: "Get back in here and fight with me!" No breaks: "get louder and meaner until you win or someone else is crying." When Steve said "Let's stop and take a break," she realized "stopping scared me. Fighting together seemed less painful than hurting alone."

- “He shuts down; I lash out. Disastrous.” Chronic flooding “sets us up to dread communicating”; she has seen it with bosses too.
- “I’ve never once regretted calling a time-out at home or work. Not once.”

Hurt

- “I’m not sure there’s a braver sentence in the human catalog of brave sentences than ‘My feelings are hurt.’ It’s simple, vulnerable, and honest.”
- Vangelisti’s team: “Individuals who are hurt experience a combination of sadness at having been emotionally wounded and fear of being vulnerable to harm.” Hurt arises when someone’s words or actions are appraised as “causing them emotional pain.”
- It is mostly caused by close others when we feel “devalued or rejected.” Most such behaviors are “thoughtless, careless, or insensitive,” not intended, but “the more intentional an action is perceived [as], the more hurtful it feels.”
- Hurt comes with other emotions yet is “a distinct emotional experience,” like a rainbow snow cone.
- Research: answer hurt with anger and the other matches it; share hurt without anger and they tend to respond with “apologies and amends.” In her kitchen anger-matching has happened “about 1,365 times.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case

Having named belonging and its threats in chapter 9, Brown shows what opening the heart costs and requires: love grown from being seen, heartbreak as its price, trust broken down into BRAVING (including self-trust), betrayal as its violation, and defensiveness, flooding and hurt as the body’s and heart’s reactions. Her case: courage means staying vulnerable, saying “My feelings are hurt,” and repairing through accountability.

CHAPTER 11

Places We Go When Life Is Good

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
Chapter 11 turns to the emotions of a good life: joy, happiness, calm, contentment, gratitude, foreboding joy, relief and tranquility. After the open-heart risks of chapter 10, it shows what the good moments are, and that joy is the hardest to receive because it is the most vulnerable.

Chapter opening — untitled section before the first sub-heading in the book

- Epigraph, Dolly Parton: "And I wish you joy and happiness. But above all of this, I wish you love."
- "Even in 1973, Dolly clearly knew that joy and happiness are two separate emotions." "We need both, but how we experience them and how they affect us are different."
- "Joy is sudden, unexpected, short-lasting, and high-intensity." It is "characterized by a connection with others, or with God, nature, or the universe," expands thinking and attention, and fills us with "a sense of freedom and abandon."
- "Happiness is stable, longer-lasting, and normally the result of effort. It's lower in intensity than joy, and more self-focused." We feel "a sense of being in control." Joy is more internal; happiness "seems more external and circumstantial."
- Anne Robertson: joy is chairo, the "culmination of being" and "good mood of the soul." "They say its opposite is not sadness, but fear."

Joy

- Definition: "I define joy as an intense feeling of deep spiritual connection, pleasure, and appreciation."
- Matthew Kuan Johnson: in joy "we don't lose ourselves, we become more truly ourselves"; "colors seem brighter" and "smiling happens involuntarily."
- Her greatest lesson from two decades: the relationship between joy and gratitude, an "intriguing upward spiral": gratitude predicts joy, joy predicts gratitude, and joy predicts greater future "subjective well-being." "It all just spirals up."
- Story from Daring Greatly: at Hermann Park, in a paddleboat, first-grader Ellen sat still, head tilted back, eyes closed, "a quiet smile on her face." She said, "I was just making a picture memory," taken "when I'm really, really happy." Brown: "there's no question that I was witnessing joy."

Happiness

- "There's really no consensus in the research when it comes to defining happiness." Most research treats it as a trait, not a state: of about fifteen thousand articles, only twelve focused on "state happiness," "0.08 percent of studies."
- Her definition of the state: "feeling pleasure often related to the immediate environment or current circumstances."
- But "the pursuit of happiness may get in the way of deeper, more meaningful experiences like joy and gratitude." In parenting, what makes children happy in the moment "is not always what leads them to developing deeper joy, grounded confidence, and meaningful connection."

Calm

- "I define calm as creating perspective and mindfulness while managing emotional reactivity." Calm people "bring perspective to complicated situations and experience their feelings without reacting to heightened emotions."
- Cultivating calm centers on "breath, perspective taking, and curiosity." Harriet Lerner: "Anxiety is contagious… Calm is also contagious. Nothing is more important than getting a grip on your own reactivity."
- Her two questions: "Do I have enough information to freak out? The answer is normally no. Will freaking out help? The answer is always no."

Contentment

- Contentment "is about satisfaction, and that, ironically, is an unsatisfying idea for a lot of people," in a world demanding "OMG-level exciting" life. Yet we are desperate for "enoughness."
- Definition: "the feeling of completeness, appreciation, and 'enoughness' that we experience when our needs are satisfied." It is a low-arousal positive emotion: "comfy, old-pair-of-jeans emotions."
- On one instrument "71 percent of the variance in life satisfaction" comes from a single item: "All things considered, how satisfied are you with your life as a whole these days?" Her question: "stop taking for granted what we have so we can experience real contentment and enoughness?"

Gratitude

- Joy, contentment and gratitude "have appreciation in common." Gratitude is correlated with "better sleep, increased creativity," and "decreased blood pressure," but she struggled to see why until Robert Emmons.
- Emmons: "positive emotions wear off quickly. Our emotional systems like newness." Gratitude "makes us appreciate the value of something," so "we're less likely to take it for granted." "Instead of adapting to goodness, we celebrate goodness." "We become greater participants in our lives as opposed to spectators."
- Definition: "Gratitude is an emotion that reflects our deep appreciation for what we value, what brings meaning to our lives, and what makes us feel connected to ourselves and others."
- Beyond "an attitude of gratitude," it is a practice: "An attitude is a way of thinking; a practice is a way of doing, trying, failing, and trying again." Examples: journals, prayers, team check-ins, and her family sharing one gratitude at dinner.
- Caveat: "gratitude is not a cure for anything."

Foreboding Joy

- "Joy is the most vulnerable human emotion." If you wait "for the other shoe to drop—you are not alone." It's called "foreboding joy," and "95 percent of the parents we interviewed experience foreboding joy with their children."
- "When we lose our tolerance for vulnerability, joy becomes foreboding." "No emotion is more frightening than joy, because we believe if we allow ourselves to feel joy, we are inviting disaster." We "start dress-rehearsing tragedy in the best moments of our lives."
- The cost: "When we push away joy, we squander the goodness that we need to build resilience, strength, and courage."
- Everyone with a deep capacity for joy "practiced gratitude." They treat the quiver of vulnerability "as a reminder to practice gratitude."

Relief

- Roseman and Evdokas: relief is "feelings of tension leaving the body and being able to breathe more easily, thoughts of the worst being over and being safe for the moment, resting, and wanting to get on to something else."

Tranquility

- Tranquility "is associated with the absence of demand" and "no pressure to do anything." Kaplan and Kaplan: a restorative environment has "a sense of getting away, a feeling of immersion, holding attention without effort, and compatibility with one's preferences."
- Versus contentment: "With contentment, we often have the sense of having completed something; with tranquility, we relish the feeling of doing nothing."

How this chapter builds the author's case

Chapter 10 showed the risk of an open heart; chapter 11 shows the reward and the catch. Joy, happiness, calm, contentment, gratitude, relief and tranquility are distinguished carefully, but the

pivot is foreboding joy: joy is vulnerable, we rehearse tragedy to protect ourselves, and gratitude practice is the way to keep receiving goodness.

CHAPTER 12

Places We Go When We Feel Wronged

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
Chapter 12 covers six experiences tied to perceived wrongs: anger, contempt, disgust, dehumanization, hate and self-righteousness. They run from the most familiar emotion to the most dangerous, and the chapter closes by turning the lens back on ourselves.

Anger

- Anger "is an emotion that we feel when something gets in the way of a desired outcome or when we believe there's a violation of the way things should be." We believe "someone or something else is to blame for an unfair or unjust situation, and that something can be done to resolve the problem."
- "Anger is an action emotion." Spielberger: it varies "from mild irritation or annoyance to fury and rage." It is also "a full-contact emotion": it "can hijack our thoughts and behaviors," and "regulating and coping with anger rather than holding on to or expressing chronic anger is crucial" for brain and body.

What I've Learned, Unlearned, and Continue to Learn About Anger. Dammit.

- She long said anger is "a secondary or 'indicator' emotion that often conceals emotions that are harder to recognize, name, or own." Then: "According to 91 percent of emotions experts, I'm wrong."
- About 7,500 people named on average three emotions: "glad, sad, and mad." Anger stories "unfolded into stories of betrayal, fear, grief, injustice, shame, vulnerability." With interviews of "more than fifteen hundred therapists and counselors," she grew surer: "it's much easier to say 'I'm so pissed off' than 'I feel so betrayed and hurt.'"
- The question: "In the face of injustice, can we just be enraged, furious, angry?" Her answer: "yes, and…" As "a former union organizer and lifelong activist, I think anger is often the most compassionate response to experiencing or witnessing injustice."
- From Braving the Wilderness: "When we deny ourselves the right to be angry, we deny our pain." Yet "Get angry and stay angry!" is not borne out by research: maintaining "rage, anger, or contempt (that favorite concoction of a little anger and a little disgust)" over time "is not sustainable." Holding on "will make us exhausted and sick"; we must transform it into "courage, love, change, compassion, justice." It is "a powerful catalyst but a life-sucking companion."
- Primary or not? "I don't know." Three things she does know: anger "often masks emotions that are more difficult to name and/or more difficult to own"; it "tells us to pull over and check things out"; and "a catalyst sparks change, it's not the change."

Contempt

- Pamela Meyer: "When someone is angry at you, you've still got traction with them, but when they display contempt, you've been dismissed."
- John Gottman calls contempt "perhaps the most corrosive force in marriage," a strong predictor of divorce (prediction "with over 90 percent accuracy"). It is one of the Four Horsemen with criticism, defensiveness and stonewalling. "What separates contempt from criticism is the intention to insult and psychologically abuse your partner."
- It includes "sarcasm and condescension," "name-calling, mimicking," eye-rolling. It "conveys disgust and superiority" and "says, 'I'm better than you. And you are lesser than me.'"
- It "results in distancing, ignoring, or excluding." The "key distinguishing feature between contempt and anger" is "the perception that the contemptible person is incapable of change." The contemptuous person "wants or needs to feel better about themselves" and likely feels "low self-esteem, inadequacy, and shame."
- Arthur Brooks: "motive attribution asymmetry"—"the assumption that your ideology is based in love, while your opponent's is based in hate"—leads to "contempt, which is a noxious brew of anger

and disgust." Schopenhauer: "the unsullied conviction of the worthlessness of another." We need "to disagree better—without contempt or cruelty."

Disgust

- Five items from the Disgust Scale-Revised, such as refusing soup "stirred by a used but thoroughly washed flyswatter." Haidt's puzzle: why does "this food-related emotion" extend to "social and moral violations that don't involve anything physically contaminating?"

Understanding Disgust

- "With contempt, we look down on the other person and we want to exclude or ignore them. With disgust, inferiority is not the issue, the feeling is more physical—we want to avoid being 'poisoned' (either literally or figuratively)." Pinker: "intuitive microbiology." Ekman: it "arises as a feeling of aversion towards something offensive," from "intense loathing" to mild dislike.
- Core disgust protects the body; interpersonally it "protect[s]" us from "contamination of the soul." But it becomes "weaponized against people who make us sick, simply because we either disagree with them or they are different from us."
- Miceli and Castelfranchi: it "can rapidly lead to dehumanizing, othering, and marginalizing." Once dehumanized, "violence and cruelty toward them become easier" because "the parts of us that are hardwired to not hurt other people turn off."
- The judgment "seems to be permanent." "At least with anger, an apology or reparation has the potential to reverse the damage done."

Dehumanization

- "Dehumanization continues to be one of the greatest threats to humanity." David Livingstone Smith: deep inhibitions stop us treating people like animals; "Dehumanization is a way of subverting those inhibitions."
- Michelle Maiese: "the psychological process of demonizing the enemy, making them seem less than human and hence not worthy of humane treatment." It starts with an enemy image; conflict becomes good versus evil and "zero-sum thinking develops."
- It has "fueled innumerable acts of violence, human rights violations, war crimes, and genocides." It "creates **moral exclusion**": the targeted group falls "out of the scope of who is naturally protected by our moral code."
- "Dehumanizing always starts with language, often followed by images." Nazis said "Untermenschen—subhuman"; Hutus called Tutsis cockroaches; Serbs called Bosnians aliens.
- Such language "taps into 'core disgust'": "We reduce people into the things that make us grossed out." "Language matters," and "with awareness about how dehumanization works comes the responsibility to call out dangerous language when we recognize it."

Hate

- Sternberg: hate combines "repulsion, disgust, anger, fear, and contempt," felt toward those "intentionally malicious and unlikely to change." We can hate strangers by group affiliation. Lack of contact strengthens it: "people are harder to hate close up."
- Hate is fueled by our need for connection: **common enemy intimacy**. "We hate the same people and that creates a counterfeit bond and a sense of belonging." The belonging is not real: it hinges on "not challenging the ideas that connect us."
- Hate travels on a "current" provided by "cynical leaders who capitalize on people's insecurities to bolster their own power."
- Hate crime victims "are terrorized for who they are, not for what they have done." Most devastating: "the goal of hate is not merely to hurt, but to ultimately eliminate or destroy the target."
- Sternberg: no "magic bullet," but "any mechanism that helps one understand things from others' points of view" (love, critical thinking, wisdom) "at least makes hate less likely, because it is harder to hate people if you understand that in many respects they are not all so different from you."

Self-Righteousness

- Twenty-five years ago an AA speaker said letting go of self-righteousness is hard “because it feels so good. Like a pig rolling in shit.” She thought: “I think I roll around in that shit too.”
- “Self-righteousness is the conviction that one’s beliefs and behaviors are the most correct.” Such people are “closed-minded, inflexible, intolerant of ambiguity.”
- Righteousness is “appropriately reacting to a true injustice”; self-righteousness is feeling “morally superior to others.” When moral outrage “is self-enhancing, it is self-righteous anger.”
- She had to stop “assuming that people who disagreed with me didn’t care about people or issues as much as I did.” “‘I’m better than’ can slip into ‘I’m worthless’ in mere seconds. Letting go of the first slowly releases us from the second.” Today she sees “performative moral outrage, especially on social media” as the pig rolling in it.

How this chapter builds the author’s case

Chapter 12 follows anger down a path. Anger is an indicator and a catalyst; contempt and disgust are judgments about people’s worth; dehumanization and hate are what those judgments produce when language strips people of humanity; self-righteousness is the check on ourselves. The thread is language: it can mask feelings or “strip people of their dignity and humanity.”

CHAPTER 13

Places We Go to Self-Assess

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
Chapter 13 closes the emotion chapters with three ways we assess ourselves: pride, hubris and humility. Brown says "Most of the quotes have it wrong."

Pride

- "Pride is a feeling of pleasure or celebration related to our accomplishments or efforts." Researchers call it **authentic pride**: "accomplishment," "mastery," "triumph." It is "positively associated with self-esteem and negatively associated with shame-proneness."
- Williams and Davies: there is a "family of pride experiences."
- Ronda Dearing notes a common use that does not fit, as in "Pride got in the way" or "He was too proud to accept help." Context and story are needed: "It could be anything—hubris, fear, shame, defensiveness." "Stay curious."

Hubris

- "Hubris is an inflated sense of one's own innate abilities that is tied more to the need for dominance than to actual accomplishments." It is negatively correlated with self-esteem and positively with narcissism and shame-proneness: "the higher the hubris, the lower the self-esteem."
- Dominance is "coerced through aggression or intimidation"; prestige is earned. To the person experiencing it, "it feels good." Dominance "does not require respect or social acceptance."
- "Narcissism is shame-based. In fact, I define **narcissism** as the shame-based fear of being ordinary." Tracy's research: for the narcissist, positive self-views "are too essential to leave to the whim of actual accomplishments," so they feel "a globalized 'hubristic' pride."
- The price: "chronic anxiety," "aggression and hostility," and trouble with "intimate partner relationships."

Humility

- "Hubris" is Greek for a pride so great it offends the gods; "humility" comes from Latin humilitas, "meaning groundedness." It is "quieter but more genuine and ultimately more powerful than hubris."
- "Humility is openness to new learning combined with a balanced and accurate assessment of our contributions, including our strengths, imperfections, and opportunities for growth." In one sentence: "I'm here to get it right, not to be right."
- It is not "downplaying yourself or your accomplishments," which is "modesty." It is not "low self-esteem or meekness or letting people walk all over you." It means understanding our contributions "in relation to both the contributions of others and our own place in the universe."
- "Intellectual humility" is "a willingness to consider information that doesn't fit with our current thinking."
- "Pride can be good for us, hubris is dangerous, and humility is key to grounded confidence and healthy relationships."

How this chapter builds the author's case
After chapters on shame, perfectionism and self-righteousness, chapter 13 sorts healthy from unhealthy self-regard. Pride is earned, hubris covers shame, and humility leads to the "grounded confidence" that the closing chapter makes central.

CLOSING CHAPTER

Cultivating Meaningful Connection

Place in the argument — why this chapter, why this title
This closing chapter turns the book's 87 entries into one theory of how we connect. It follows the Introduction's claim that the anchor we are searching for is connection. Brown first explains theory-building (Theory), adds the missing piece (Near Enemies), lays out the three-part theory with its sub-sections, shows language as the thread through all of it (Language and Meaningful Connection), and ends on her mother's lesson and the atlas metaphor (Atlas of the Heart).

Theory

- Doyle's epigraph: "It is a capital mistake to theorize before one has data." Dr. Paul Raffoul drew "the circle of science" on the board.
- "As a grounded theory researcher, I work up from the bottom of that circle, following an inductive approach and generating theories from mostly qualitative data." She loves "language, words, and story." Her theories are then tested "using deductive and quantitative methods." "We should not test and build on theories that are just conjecture—especially when it comes to hypothesizing about underrepresented groups." "The value is in the full circle."
- "We all have theories," such as about traffic patterns near your house.
- Kerlinger defines theory as "A set of interrelated constructs (concepts), definitions, and propositions that present a systematic view of phenomena specifying relations among variables, with the purpose of explaining and predicting the phenomena." "Theorizing is part of meaning-making—it's how we explain the relationships between different variables."
- The only difference from everyday theories: hers "are based on observations or data that we methodically collect and analyze." Colleagues then test them, and "the findings evolve and our level of understanding keeps getting closer and closer to 'truth.'"

Near Enemies

- This is "a theory on cultivating meaningful connection," the "culmination of my work since the beginning"; her dissertation was on connection. "there was something missing" until she was "rediscovering the Buddhist concept of near enemies." For years she had "underestimated this concept's power."
- Germer: "Near enemies are states that appear similar to the desired quality but actually undermine it. Far enemies are the opposite of what we are trying to achieve." A near enemy of loving-kindness is sentimentality, a far enemy is ill will; a near enemy of compassion is pity, a far enemy is cruelty. This nuance "predicts the difference between wholeheartedness and brokenheartedness."
- Kornfield: "The near enemies depict how spirituality can be misunderstood or misused to separate us from life." She defines spirituality as "the deeply held belief that we are inextricably connected to each other by something greater than ourselves"; it is not about religion.
- Her translation: "On the surface, the near enemies of emotions or experiences might look and even feel like connection, but ultimately they drive us to be disconnected from ourselves and from each other." "This is huge."
- Kornfield on love: "The near enemy of love is attachment. Attachment masquerades as love." "True love allows, honors, and appreciates; attachment grasps, demands, needs, and aims to possess." On equanimity: "The near enemy of equanimity is indifference or callousness." "True equanimity is not a withdrawal; it is a balanced engagement with all aspects of life."
- The far enemies are "easy to recognize" and "up front with their disconnection." It is the near enemies, "the imposters that can look and feel like cultivating closeness," that "sabotage relationships and leave us feeling alone and in pain." "Of course the far enemies destroy connection too—but you see them coming."

A Grounded Theory on Cultivating Meaningful Connection

- "Cultivating meaningful connection is a daring and vulnerable practice that requires grounded confidence, the courage to walk alongside others, and story stewardship." Each of the three categories "has its own near and far enemies, as does each of the skill sets that support those categories."

Developing Grounded Confidence

- Introduced in Dare to Lead, whose core learning is "it's not fear that gets in the way of courage, it's armor." As we remove our armor "we replace it with grounded confidence."
- It is "driven by a commitment to learning and improving." Its near enemy is "knowing and proving," which are "actually a function of low self-worth." The far enemy is "fragile self-worth," which "drives us to self-protect at all costs."
- Its last skill is feeling embodied and connected to self. Van der Kolk: "Trauma victims cannot recover until they become familiar with and befriend the sensations in their bodies." "Physical self-awareness is the first step in releasing the tyranny of the past."
- Prentis Hemphill defines embodiment as "the awareness of our body's sensations, habits, and the beliefs that inform them," and disembodiment as "an unawareness, repression or denial of our sensations and emotions," which "often leads to an incongruence between the actions we take in the world and the beliefs that we hold."
- For Brown, "the best indicator light around being out of values is my body." "Our bodies are our teachers and the messengers," which is why "grounded confidence requires embodiment."

Practicing the Courage to Walk Alongside

- Guiding questions: "What does it mean to be other-focused, to use language in the service of connecting, to be compassionate, empathic, and nonjudgmental?" It echoes her dissertation theory, "Acompañar," "to accompany": "not pushing them from behind or leading from the front, but walking with them in solidarity."
- The near enemy is "controlling the path." Her example: a child in trouble at school, and "I want to be with you in this" becomes "You need to email your teacher and apologize right this minute." Lamott: "Help is the sunny side of control." The question: "Whose best interest are you protecting? Walking alongside is other-focused. Control is self-focused."
- Politicians do it too; this near enemy "is often as dangerous as the far enemy: walking away."
- Power: King defined it as "the ability to achieve purpose and effect change"; what makes it dangerous "is how it's used." **Power over** is dangerous "because it's using disproportional influence to achieve gain, even when that diminishes the agency and/or dignity of others." **Power with** is "based on mutual support, solidarity, collaboration and recognition and respect for differences"; **power to** on "the belief that each individual has the power to make a difference"; **power within** on "a strong foundation of self-worth and self-knowledge."
- The far enemy, walking away, includes "ignoring, dismissing, power over, and building walls." "Control and power-over masquerading as connection is especially destructive."

Practicing Story Stewardship

- A reversal: for two decades she said we must understand emotion "so we can recognize it in ourselves and others." Now: "I no longer believe that we can recognize emotion in other people." Two reasons: "Too many emotions and experiences present the exact same way" (tears could be grief, despair, hopelessness or resentment), and expression "can be as unique as we are." So "we ask them."
- **Story stewardship** "means honoring the sacred nature of story—the ones we share and the ones we hear." We are good stewards of our own stories "by trusting them to people who have earned the right to hear them," and of others' "by listening, being curious, affirming, and believing people when they tell us how they experienced something."

- Near enemy: “performing connection while driving disconnection,” such as “being the knower, advice-giving, and problem-solving.” Better: “I can listen and be with you, I can help problem-solve, or whatever else you need. You tell me.”
- Two near enemies of narrative trust: **narrative tap-out** (“This is too uncomfortable”) and **narrative takeover**, where “we hijack the story and center ourselves.” Rejecting someone’s story is often “about protecting our ego, behavior, or privilege.” Example: “all lives matter” in response to Black Lives Matter, an attempt to “decenter Black lives and take over the narrative.”
- “Like empathy, story stewardship is not walking in someone else’s shoes.” The far enemy is “fueling narrative distrust.” “When we are reckless with people’s stories, we diminish our own humanity.”

Language and Meaningful Connection

- Knowing and applying the language of human experience “is a key property of all of the major categories.” She realized “I can’t write a book on meaningful connection without including some kind of glossary or compendium of emotion and experience words.” That it is central to all three “speaks to its power.”
- The near enemy is “shaping emotion and experience to fit what we know”: forcing despair or hopelessness into “sadness or anger” leaves us “far less capable of sharing what we’re experiencing, getting help, or moving through our experiences productively.” The far enemy is “acting out, shutting down, or giving up.”

Atlas of the Heart

- Her mother taught them “to never look away from pain”: “Don’t look away. Don’t look down.” “Look people in the eye.” “We need to know we’re not alone—especially when we’re hurting.”
- Her learning: “our emotions and experiences are layers of biology, biography, behavior, and backstory.” And: “Our connection with others can only be as deep as our connection with ourselves.” She had made self-connection “optional if I had anything left after connecting with others. It wasn’t working.”
- Emotions leave “our hearts stretch-marked and strong, worn and willing.”
- Her hope: “that we find that solid ground within us, that shore that offers safe harbor when we’re feeling untethered and adrift.” The gift of language is “being able to go anywhere without the fear of getting lost”: “with the right map, we can find our way back to our heart and to our truest self.”

How this chapter builds the author’s case

This chapter answers the Introduction’s promise. The Introduction said the anchor is connection and the route is language; here the 87 terms become a theory with three categories, each with its near and far enemies (with pity and sympathy named earlier as near enemies of compassion and empathy), and the shore Rumi’s epigraph pointed to is “that solid ground within us.”

Not summarised

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